

TE A'A O TE TŌ'EA

(The Path of the Plover)

In the Marquesan language, with subtitles. Written here in English.

PROLOGUE

BLACK.

A woman's voice, far off, singing. A line that goes down and down: names, one after another. Too faint to catch a word.

Then wings, thousands of them, a sound like surf pulled the wrong way, and it covers the voice.

It builds, passes over, and thins to nothing.

FADE IN:

EXT. NUKU HIVA — BEACH — DAWN

The light is grey and so is the water. A beach runs the length of the frame.

The last of a great flock of golden plovers lifts off the wet sand, a thousand small bodies turning in one motion, and goes out over the water. For a moment the sky is birds. Then a line, and then a dark mark on the sky, low over the sea, going north.

Two figures in the shallows, knee-deep. TEIKI, thirties, a navigator, lean and salt-cracked, his skin dark with old tattoo. Beside him, holding his hand, MANU, six.

They watch the birds go.

NAVIGATOR Keep watching them. Don't look away until you can't see them any more.

The boy watches. The mark on the sky goes on shrinking, and does not come down.

NAVIGATOR They're still going. They haven't come down.

MANU Where are they going?

NAVIGATOR A bird has to sleep on land. Those birds can't stop on the water; if they came down on it they'd drown. And they won't come down tonight, or tomorrow night, or the night

after. So wherever they do come down, it's land.

The boy looks at the water, then at the horizon.

MANU There's nothing there.

NAVIGATOR That's what everyone says.

He crouches so their eyes are level. He points north, along the line the birds took, and moves the boy's small hand until it points the same way.

NAVIGATOR Every spring they get fat and they go. Every autumn they come back as thin as ten or twelve days of flying would make them, and they never stop on the way. So somewhere out there, ten or twelve days away, there's a beach with a thousand birds asleep on it.

The boy keeps his hand pointing. His father lets go of it and the hand stays.

MANU Why does nobody believe you?

NAVIGATOR Because I haven't come back yet.

He stands.

NAVIGATOR When I come back, they'll have to.

Behind them, drawn up on the sand, is a small single-hulled canoe with gourds lashed under the thwarts, a rolled mat sail, and one paddle.

He wades to it. The boy follows him out of the water.

MANU Take me.

The Navigator puts a shoulder to the hull and it moves.

MANU Take me.

NAVIGATOR You'd be a weight.

He says it kindly. He does not look back when he says it.

The canoe is in the water. He is in the canoe. The paddle goes in. The gap between the hull and the sand is one pace, then three, then the width of a house.

The boy stands on the wet sand with his arms at his sides.

Then he runs.

Into the surf, to his waist, to his chest, screaming, not a word, just the sound. A wave knocks him flat. He comes up and goes on.

Up the beach, TAMATOA, sixteen, already a man's shoulders, comes down the sand at a dead run. He hits the water without slowing, reaches the boy in four strides, and hauls him out by one arm the way you land a fish.

He throws him on the sand. He lies on him.

The boy fights and bites. Tamatoa does not hit him. He holds on.

Over Tamatoa's shoulder the boy can see the sail, and it is already small.

MANU (*into the sand*) Let me go. Let me go. Let me —

TAMATOA No.

They lie there. The boy stops fighting, not because he has given up but because he cannot see the sail if he fights.

The sail gets smaller.

Tamatoa is not watching the sail. He is watching the water under it.

The sail is a fleck. Then the light changes on the sea and it is not there, and it does not come back.

Tamatoa gets off him. The boy stays on his stomach, face turned to the water.

TAMATOA He's not coming back.

MANU He said —

TAMATOA I know what he said. He's been saying it since I was your size.

He picks the boy up under the arms and sets him on his feet, and stands behind him with a hand on each shoulder, and the two of them look north at nothing.

The last plover on the beach, a straggler, a thin one, lifts off the sand beside them and goes after the rest.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD.

ACT ONE

EXT. NUKU HIVA — RIDGELINE — DAY

Ash is falling, not much of it, a grey drift like the first minutes of snow, settling on black

ground. The hill below the ridge was burned to plant it, and the planting failed, and now it is bare to the rock. Across the valley, a second hill is burning now, and beyond it a column of smoke leans over a village.

Terraces step down the slope, and the mud in them is cracked into plates.

On a shelf of flat rock near the top, MANU, twenty-one, sits cross-legged inside a ring of pebbles. His hair is loose to his shoulders. Warriors wear it knotted.

Thirty-two stones, each the size of a thumb-joint, laid in a circle two arm-spans across, and the circle is exact. Each stone is a place on the horizon where one star comes up or goes down. He has watched every one of them come up and go down for fifteen years, and there are stones here for stars that only rise for a few nights a year.

Across the ring, cutting it, a straight line of smaller pebbles with a stick standing at one end: the noon shadow of the stick, marked every ten days, year after year. The marks walk north up the rock, and stop, and walk back. He has measured the sun turning.

Beside him lie dozens of coiled cords, each knotted along its length. The knots are a writing: their spacing is the day a flock left, by which star rose that dawn; their size is how heavy the birds were; a second cord twisted round the first is the heading they took, and there are fifteen years of it. He has one across his knees and is running it through his fingers with his eyes shut, and he is not remembering, he is reading.

He stops and opens his eyes, leans out, and moves one pebble a thumb's width to the left. He looks at it, and moves it back.

Below the shelf, where the ridge meets the rocks above the bay, MOEATA, sixties, sits with a net across her lap. Her hands, cracked white at every joint from fifty years of twine, do not stop.

She glances up the slope, and back to the net.

MOEATA You've moved that stone four times.

MANU It's the wrong stone.

His hands, on the cord, are clean. Nobody else's on the island are.

MOEATA Then move a different one.

He picks up the cord again and counts knots under his breath: ten, twelve, fourteen.

Ash settles on the pebbles. He brushes each one clean with a fingertip before he goes on.

MOEATA The long swell came in from the wrong side this morning.

He goes on counting.

She stops working. She lays her palm flat on the wet net where it is spread on the rock, and holds it there, and her eyes go to the water.

MOEATA I felt it in the net. It usually comes in from the sunrise side, and this one's coming from the south. It's been ten days like that.

He goes on counting.

MOEATA That's the winter swell, and it's early.

MANU I've never seen a swell arrive on a date.

She goes on with the net.

MANU (*polite*) I'll make a note of it.

He does not note it. He holds the cord up against the sun and closes one eye.

Moeata's hands keep working.

MOEATA Your father used to sit there.

MANU He sat here.

She nods at a place two paces down the slope, where the rock is worn smooth in a shape that could be a man.

MOEATA He sat there, two paces down, where you can see the water.

Manu does not look up.

MANU I'm not watching the water.

She ties a knot in the net, bites the thread.

A plover lands on the rock at the edge of his circle, fat and sleek and wintering. It walks along the outside of the pebbles as if it has been shown the line and does not cross it.

Manu goes very still.

He and the bird regard each other.

MANU (*to the bird, quietly*) Five months, and then you go.

The bird pecks at something in the ash.

Manu picks up a second cord and lays it beside the first, end to end, and then a third. His lips move: fourteen, twenty, twenty-five.

Down on the rocks, Moeata looks at the swell coming in wrong, and at the boy on the hill

who is looking at the sky, and says nothing, because she has already said it.

The ash keeps falling. He keeps the stones clean.

CUT TO:

EXT. BEACH — DAWN

Grey light, and plovers on the wet sand, fat and slow.

Manu, flat on his belly at the edge of the grass with a throw-net, Moeata's net, folded in his hands. He waits a long time. Then the net goes out and comes back with a bird in it.

He does not look at the bird the way a hungry man would. He looks at it the way Akau looks at an arm.

A paddle balanced across a peg driven into a log: a beam. The bird, hooded with a scrap of bark cloth so it will lie still, on one end. On the other, stones, added one at a time from a pile he has sorted by size, until the paddle floats level. He counts the stones. He ties a knot in a fresh cord, and its size is that number.

He runs a length of cord from wing-tip to wing-tip, and ties another knot.

He carries the bird to the water's edge, takes off the hood, and lets it go. It runs, and lifts, and flies along the beach toward the headland.

He is counting under his breath, and it is not the bird he is counting but his own heartbeat. The headland is a known distance; he has paced it. When the bird reaches it he stops counting and ties a knot for that too.

Moeata, up the beach with her net-bag, has been watching all of it.

MOEATA That's my net.

MANU I'll bring it back.

MOEATA You've had it since the last moon.

MANU You weren't using it.

He is already tying the next knot.

EXT. VILLAGE — DAY

Houses on platforms of fitted black stone, thatch pitched low, under trees stripped for fodder. Between them, the breadfruit pits, stone-lined holes where a village keeps fermented paste against a bad year. A woman kneels at one with her arm in it to the

shoulder. She brings the arm out with nothing on it. Dogs too thin to bark, keeping their distance.

And under everything, the sound that is the sound of every village: women beating bark cloth on a log, wooden beaters going in turn, a rhythm with a gap in it. Here the gap is wide. Half the beaters are silent.

At the water's edge a woman stands in the shallows holding an infant face-down in the sea, letting it kick. Babies here swim before they walk. A child sitting in a doorway with the stillness of a child who has stopped expecting anything.

Two men are on the ground in the open space between the houses, fighting, and it is not a warrior's fight; it is elbows and teeth. Between them, rolling in the dust, a breadfruit gone soft and brown.

INT. THE OLD CHANTER'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

It is dark inside, with a shaft of light from the door. THE OLD CHANTER, eighties, lies on a mat, most of the way to somewhere else. Her breath is a small dry sound.

HINA, early twenties, has hair to her waist, oiled, and wears a skirt of white bark cloth and the marks of the keepers: a blue line across each collarbone and a blue lattice on the backs of the hands. She is beautiful, and the village is too hungry to say so. She kneels with her head bent so close to the old woman's that their foreheads nearly touch. She is not holding her hand. She is listening.

A bowl of breadfruit paste beside the mat, untouched, going grey.

The old woman is singing, and it is barely a voice: a line, a name, another name, the melody going down and down.

OLD CHANTER (*sung, a thread*) ...Tehea, who was born of Puaiki, who was born of the woman who came in the canoe, and the canoe was called...

She stops and breathes. Hina waits with her lips already shaped for the next word.

Outside there is a shout, and the sound of a body hitting the ground.

Hina does not move.

The old woman finds the thread.

OLD CHANTER (*sung*) ...and the canoe was called Te Ivi, and she was cut from the tree at...

Another shout, closer, and the doorway darkens as one of the men rolls across it.

Hina closes her eyes for one breath. Then she rises, crosses to the door, and stands in the light.

EXT. VILLAGE — CONTINUOUS

The two men, PUA and FETU, both thirties, both hungry, have each other by the throat.

Hina does not raise her voice. She sings.

HINA (*sung, clear, not loud*) Pua, son of Tehau. Tehau, son of Meama.

Pua's grip loosens. He has heard his own name in the shape it takes in the chant, and it has stopped his hands.

HINA (*sung*) Fetu, son of Ani. Ani, daughter of Meama.

There is silence. The two men look at each other from a hand's width away. They are cousins, and they knew it, but they had never heard it sung.

Hina goes back inside. The breadfruit lies in the dust between them and neither of them picks it up.

INT. THE OLD CHANTER'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Hina kneels. The old woman's lips are moving but nothing is coming.

HINA (*softly*) And she was cut from the tree at —

The old woman's eyes find her. She tries. The sound will not come.

Hina bends her head and sings the line herself, low, the melody going down.

HINA (*sung*) ...and she was cut from the tree at Hakaui, in the year the mountain smoked, by Tumu, who was the first of us.

The old woman's mouth closes. Her breathing goes on a little longer, and then it does not.

Hina stays where she is. Her lips move, silently, from the top. She is going back through it, every name, making sure she has it.

Outside, a sound starts at the far end of the village and comes toward the house like weather: running feet, and voices, and under the voices a word.

The word is *Tamatoa*.

EXT. BEACH — DAY

The whole village on the sand, or what is left of it. Everyone is thinner than they were a year ago, and everyone can see it on everyone else.

Three war canoes coming in on the swell. TAMATOA, thirties, stands in the bow of the first with a whale-bone club across his shoulders like a yoke, the flared head carved with a face. Tattooed to the eyelids, the face barred black with charcoal for the raid, the hair up in a

warrior's two knots. A collar of boar tusks; under it, one whale tooth on a cord. At his knees, tassels of human hair. A cut over one eye has bled down his face and dried, and he has not wiped it.

Behind the canoes, across the bay, the far side of the island is burning. It is not the hills that are burning but the low ground, where the storage pits are, and the smoke goes up in a dark column, straight, because there is no wind.

Someone on the sand has a drum, a tall wooden pahu with a sharkskin head, and begins on it, and the beat is the thing the crowd has been waiting for without knowing it.

The canoes ground. Warriors come off: young men in loincloths, inked ankle to jaw, lean under the ink, cock-feather headdresses limp with salt. The girls on the sand, thin as they are, watch them the way girls watch. Before they touch the baskets they stamp: a line of them on the wet sand, thighs slapped, tongues out, a chant like a bark, answered from the beach by whoever has the breath. It is short, because nobody has the breath. Then come the captives, six of them roped at the neck, a boy among them. Then the baskets, three of them, and a tied pig, and some gourds.

The crowd cheers. It is not a large sound.

Tamatoa comes down the beach through it. People touch him as he passes. He allows it. His eyes go to the smoke across the bay and stay there.

ROA, thirties, a hard man with a soft wife, falls in beside him.

TAMATOA (*low, not stopping*) How much did we get?

ROA Three baskets.

TAMATOA How long will that feed them?

RoA looks at the crowd.

ROA Three days. Maybe four.

Tamatoa nods as if he had known the number before he asked, and he has.

At the top of the beach, Hina is standing with the captives. She has stopped beside the boy on the rope. She is speaking to him, quietly, and he is answering.

Tamatoa arrives. He puts his hand on the back of her neck and leaves it there.

TAMATOA What are you doing?

HINA I'm asking him his mother's name.

TAMATOA You don't need their names.

HINA Someone will need them.

He looks at her. She has not turned to look at him. His hand stays on her neck a moment longer than it needs to, and then he takes it away and walks on up the beach to where the Chief is waiting, and the crowd goes after him.

Hina stays with the boy.

HINA Say it again.

The boy says his mother's name. Hina says it back to him, once, exactly, and then she goes.

EXT. RIDGELINE — DUSK

The sky going orange over the sea. The smoke across the bay has turned copper at the top and black underneath.

Manu inside his ring of stones. He has not moved all day except to keep the ash off.

Hina comes up the path with the last of the light on her, orange on the oil in her hair. He hears her and does not look.

She stops at the edge of the circle. She does not cross the pebbles.

HINA The old woman died this morning.

He goes on with the cord.

HINA There is a verse in the keeping about a land. Nobody knows where it is. The whole island knows what you say about the birds. Which way do they go?

He lifts one hand without looking up and points north, along the line of the stones. It is the same gesture his father made, and the same angle.

She looks that way. There is nothing there but the light going.

Then, low, not for him, she sings.

HINA (*sung*) ...and they went to where the sun's path turns back, and the sea was without a floor, and they came to the mountain whose hair is white...

Manu's hands stop on the cord.

HINA (*sung*) ...and they came home, and sang it, and the ones who heard it are the ones we come from.

There is a silence. Manu has not turned around.

MANU Where is that from?

HINA It's from the keeping. Only the keepers have it. There have been seven of them in two hundred years, and not one of them knew what it meant. The old woman didn't, and her teacher didn't. They kept it anyway. There's a line in it about where the sun's path turns back, and nobody has ever known what it means.

He is looking at the stones now. His finger goes to one of them, near the northern edge of the ring.

MANU Every year the sun walks north until it stops and comes back. The land is where it stops. That's ten days for a bird, maybe twelve.

He looks up at her. He has not, until now.

MANU So they went there.

HINA We sing that they went there.

MANU And they came back.

HINA They came back, and nobody kept the road.

MANU What?

HINA They kept the mountain, and the sun turning back, and the three sisters going under, because those are things that sing. A heading doesn't, so the heading went, and in five generations the whole thing was a verse nobody could use.

She looks at his cords.

He puts a hand flat on the rock, as if the rock has moved.

MANU Fifteen years I've been saying it.

His voice does not do what he wants it to. He turns his face away from her, toward the sea, and does not say anything else, because if he says anything else she will hear it.

Hina watches this. She is not moved by it, or she does not let it show.

HINA Don't.

MANU I didn't say anything.

HINA I'm not here because I believe you.

He waits.

HINA I have four hundred and twelve names now, every one of them, back to the canoe that found this island and the tree it was cut from and the year. Nobody else has them, and in a year there will be no one on this island to sing them to.

She looks across at the smoke.

HINA A chant no one hears is a dead person's chant. I need to know if there's a beach.

MANU There's a beach.

HINA How do you know?

MANU I've measured it.

HINA That's not knowing.

MANU It's what I have.

She stands a moment longer. The light is nearly gone off the water.

HINA Then be right.

She turns and goes down the path.

Manu sits inside his circle in the dusk. He picks up a cord, a new one, unknotted. He runs it through his fingers to find the end.

Then he ties a knot in it. Then another, and another, his lips moving, and it is the rhythm of the chant she sang, the names, the line, the mountain: he is putting it on the cord.

Below him, on the rocks, Moeata's net lies folded where she left it, and the swell comes in from the wrong side in the dark, and there is no knot for that.

CUT TO:

EXT. WATERFALL — NIGHT

A white column of water falling into black. The sound of it fills everything.

A figure crosses the pool below, waist-deep, holding a torch high and to the side. It is Hina. She goes in behind the falling water and is gone.

INT. LAVA TUBE — CONTINUOUS

A throat of stone behind the falls, the walls ropy where the rock once ran liquid, dry underfoot and warm, the roar of the water muffled to a hum. The torch finds Manu already there, cross-legged on the floor. He has brought his stones. The ring is laid out on the rock, smaller, and beside it the cords.

Hina sets the torch in a crack and sits across the ring from him. She does not cross it.

HINA Start from the tree.

MANU From the tree.

She sings. The whole chant, from the beginning, low and steady, the genealogy going back and back. He listens with his eyes closed and a cord in his hands, and each time a canoe or a navigator is named his fingers tie a knot, counting the generations back to the crossing.

INT. LAVA TUBE — ANOTHER NIGHT

The ring of stones has grown. There are more of them, and some have been moved out of the circle to make a second shape beside it, a line of five, then a gap, then three.

HINA (*sung*) ...where the sun's path turns back...

MANU Stop there. What comes just before that?

HINA (*sung*) ...and the three sisters stood on the bow, and then went under the sea...

Manu is on his knees over the stones.

MANU That's three stars close together, low in the south behind us, and then they're gone. You call them the sisters. I've only ever called them the three.

He picks up a cord, reads it with his thumb, and moves one of the three stones.

MANU They'd sink on the eighth night if the canoe went as fast as the birds. It won't. So later, the tenth night or the twelfth.

He looks up.

MANU Sing it from the sisters.

INT. LAVA TUBE — ANOTHER NIGHT

The torch has burned lower. They are closer together than they were, on the same side of the ring now, and neither has noticed doing it.

Manu is laying cords end to end across the floor.

MANU That's fifteen springs, and this is the fattest bird I ever held.

He touches a doubled knot.

MANU And this is the same bird in autumn. The difference between those two knots is what it burns to get there and back. I've watched one fly from the grass to the headland, and I know how long that takes and how far it is, so I know how fast they go. I know how much fat a bird has and how fast it burns it. A fat bird can fly fourteen days before it's a thin bird. A thin bird, coming back, can do ten. So the beach is between ten and fourteen days away, for a bird.

HINA And for a canoe?

MANU A canoe's slower. Twenty days, or twenty-five if the wind's wrong.

HINA And if it's thirty?

He does not answer that. He puts a stone at the end of the last cord.

MANU This is where it is.

Hina looks at the stone.

HINA It's a stone.

MANU It's a mountain whose hair is white.

She looks at him, and he is not joking.

She reaches out and moves one of his stones a thumb's width. He does not stop her.

INT. LAVA TUBE — ANOTHER NIGHT

Hina sits cross-legged, singing a line, and stops.

HINA Now you sing it.

MANU No. That's a keeper's chant, and a lesser wife's son doesn't sing a chief's line.

HINA He does tonight. Go on.

He sings it, and it is not singing; it is a man saying words at roughly the height of a note. She puts her hand over her mouth.

MANU What.

HINA Nothing. Do it again.

He does it again, and it is worse. She laughs, out loud, and it echoes off the rock and comes back at them twice.

HINA You can't sing.

MANU No.

HINA You really can't.

MANU I keep them on cords.

HINA I know you do.

She is still laughing. She picks up one of his cords, and turns it over, and runs a thumb along

the knots, and stops laughing somewhere in the middle of it, and does not put it down.

INT. LAVA TUBE — ANOTHER NIGHT

The torch is out; they have let it go out. The only light is the grey of the falling water at the mouth of the tube, and it is not much.

Manu is not looking at the stones. He is looking at the water, and at a place on the rock floor, and back at the water.

MANU Stand there.

HINA Why?

MANU Stand there and don't move.

She stands where he points. He looks at the wall of water, and at the ridge behind it that neither of them can see, and counts under his breath.

Nothing happens, and she folds her arms.

HINA How long?

MANU The moon clears the ridge in about the time it takes to sing your father's line.

HINA You've worked out where the moon comes through a waterfall.

MANU I worked it out the first night. I've been waiting for a night it was full.

The falling water goes from grey to white. The moon has come over the ridge behind it, and the light comes through the sheet of water broken into a thousand moving pieces, and every one of them lands on her.

She looks down at herself, lit, and up at him.

HINA The first night we were here.

MANU Yes.

She does not say anything for a moment. Then she laughs, and steps out of the light, and comes across the ring of stones to where he is. Nobody has crossed it on purpose before.

INT. LAVA TUBE — LATER

The hum of the water. The moon gone off the falls.

They are not talking. The stones scatter under a knee and neither of them looks down.

Bark cloth tears. Skin in firelight, hers unmarked, his inked to the ribs, and the stones under both of them.

It is not gentle.

INT. LAVA TUBE — LATER STILL

It is nearly dark, with only the embers of the torch and the sound of water on stone.

They lie on the rock. Her head is on his chest. He is looking up at nothing.

MANU Come with me.

She does not answer at once.

HINA I won't follow a dreamer.

MANU I'm not —

HINA Let me finish. I won't follow a dreamer. I'll follow a man who can put my feet on new ground.

She lifts her head and looks at him in what is left of the light.

HINA Can you?

MANU Yes.

HINA Say the rest of it.

He does not understand, and then he does.

MANU I'll give you a new world.

She puts her head back down.

Beside them, in the scattered stones, the one that was the mountain has rolled against the wall.

INT. KIATO'S HOUSE — NIGHT (WEEKS LATER)

A long house on the highest paepae. A fire in the centre of the floor, low, and around it the people who decide things: KIATO, TIHOTI, two elders, and, against the wall with a neighbour's child asleep across her lap, HINA, who is here because she is the keeper and the keeper hears everything.

By the door a young man is chewing kava root, the pepper-plant, and spitting the pulp into a wooden bowl, and wringing water through it with a twist of fibre, and the smell of it is in the house: green, and bitter, and old. When it is ready he brings the cup, a half coconut, to Kiato first, and Kiato drinks, and it goes to Tihoti, and then to the elders in the order of their houses. Nobody offers it to Hina. Nobody expects to.

After the cup comes a bowl of breadfruit paste, and each of them takes two fingers of it. It is

sour, and nobody comments.

AN ELDER The other son has been on the cliff every day since the raid, with his stones.

KIATO He has been on the cliff since he was six.

THE ELDER He has been talking to the keeper.

Kiato looks at his daughter. She does not look up from the child. He looks for long enough that the elder stops talking, and then he looks back at the fire.

KIATO *(to Tihoti)* If I give him the canoe.

TIHOTI It goes under, with everyone on it.

KIATO And if I don't?

Tihoti looks at the bowl going round, two fingers each.

TIHOTI Then we go under here, slower.

The second elder puts a husk on the fire and it flares and the faces come up out of the dark, all of them old, and go back.

THE ELDER There are two pits left, and neither is full.

Kiato nods.

KIATO If it goes, my daughter goes on it.

Hina's hand stops on the child's back.

TIHOTI Why?

KIATO Because the line goes where the food is. It always has.

He holds his hands to the fire.

KIATO And you go, priest. Somebody will have to bury them, and I want it done properly.

TIHOTI I will bury you first. You are older.

Kiato laughs. Nobody in the house has heard it in a year.

KIATO Then do it tomorrow. Tonight I am going to sleep.

He lies down by the fire, which is how a meeting in this house ends, and the others go on sitting a while, and the child on Hina's lap does not wake.

EXT. COUNCIL MARAE — NIGHT (THE NEXT NIGHT)

The marae is the village's open-air temple, a raised platform of fitted stone under the tallest trees left on the island. At its head, two stone figures taller than a man, eyes the size of hands, faces worn soft by rain. There are torches. The village's elders sit on the stones, eight or nine old men, and behind them everyone else who can stand.

Kiato sits at the head under a crown of tortoiseshell and white shell. He looks like a man who has been awake for a year. Hina sits at his left with her hands in her lap. Tihoti sits at his right with the knotted cord across his knees, very still.

Tamatoa stands in the open centre, the club at his feet.

TAMATOA Give me forty men. I take the high valley before the rains. Their pits are burned, but their trees aren't, and we take the trees.

AN ELDER And when the trees are eaten?

TAMATOA Then we take the next valley.

THE ELDER There is no next valley. You burned the last one yesterday.

TAMATOA Then we eat what's in it before it's gone.

KIATO (*tired*) Forty men, then. Roa, count them out.

MANU (O.S.) No.

Heads turn. Manu is standing at the edge of the marae with a bundle in his arms. He has never spoken here. He is the son of a lesser wife.

AN ELDER (*to the man beside him, not quietly*) The navigator's other son.

He walks into the centre, past his brother, and kneels, and unrolls the bundle onto the stones.

He begins to set out pebbles, one and then the next. Nobody stops him, because nobody has ever seen anything like it. The ring takes shape on the flat stones of the marae, thirty-odd points, exact.

TAMATOA Get up.

Manu does not get up. He lays the cords beside the ring, end to end, the way he laid them in the tube.

MANU Every spring for fifteen years the plovers have left this beach and flown north. They can't rest on water. Every autumn they come back thinner.

He touches the doubled knot.

MANU A bird this fat can fly fourteen days. There is a beach fourteen days north of here

with a thousand birds on it.

AN ELDER You're talking about birds.

MANU Birds don't drown, so wherever they go, there's land.

TAMATOA Get up, Manu.

MANU I'm asking for the canoe, Te Ivi, and I'm asking for four months to wait for the birds. They go in spring. We go when they go and we sail under them, and then we don't have to be right about anything. We just have to keep them in the sky.

AN ELDER Anyone can watch a bird fly off. That doesn't make him a navigator.

MANU Then watch a star.

He turns to the east, where the marae's platform ends and the sea begins, black.

MANU The net rises tonight between those two torches, there, when the eel, the long line of stars that stands up out of the sea in the east, is a hand above the water. You'll see the first star of it in the time it takes to sing a child's line.

Nobody sings, but they wait. The elders look at the two torches and at the black between them.

The eel climbs. A hand above the water.

Between the torches, low, a star.

Then a second, beside it. The net, coming up out of the sea exactly where he said, on the night he said, at the height of the eel he said.

Nobody says anything. Some of the elders have been watching that sky for seventy years and have never once thought to say where a star would come up before it did.

MANU *(to the elder)* I can tell you where every star in that sky will be tomorrow night. Nobody on this marae can tell me one.

The elder does not answer. Kiato looks at the son of the lesser wife for a long moment, and the look is not a kind one.

There is a silence, and the pebbles on the stones, and the cords.

Tihoti has not moved. Now he does. He stands, and the marae goes quieter than it was.

TIHOTI Your beach is north.

Manu points north, at the same angle as always.

TIHOTI Sail north and every star you were born under goes down into the sea behind you,

one by one, the sisters, the net, all of them, and does not come up again. That is the road of the dead. It is the only road that runs that way, and every navigator who has taken it has joined them.

Manu does not answer, because it is true.

He looks at the cord across his own arm.

He looks from Manu to Tamatoa, and back.

TIHOTI Your father's name is on this cord.

MANU I know where my father's name is.

TIHOTI You have birds, and I have the names of every man who followed birds. Do you want yours on here, beside his? I will tie it myself, and I will sing it properly.

Manu does not answer. Everyone sees that he doesn't.

The elders nod. Kiato is looking at the pebbles on his marae like a man looking at a mess someone else will have to clean.

Then Hina stands.

She does not step into the centre. She stays where she is, at her father's left hand, and she sings.

HINA (*sung*) ...and they went to where the sun's path turns back, and the sea was without a floor, and they came to the mountain whose hair is white...

Tihoti turns to her. He knows the verse, and his face changes.

HINA (*sung*) ...and they came home, and sang it, and the ones who heard it are the ones we come from.

She stops, and goes on in her ordinary voice.

HINA If the north is the road of the dead, the dead came home. Someone came back from there and sang it, and we are what they sang it to. It's in the keeping. You know it is.

Tihoti looks at her for a long moment.

TIHOTI The keeper has sung.

He sits down.

TIHOTI I don't argue with the names.

He does not say that Manu is right.

Kiato looks at his daughter. She does not look away. He is the one who does.

KIATO Three baskets came in today, and that is three days of food. You are asking me for four months.

MANU The birds go in —

KIATO I know when the birds go. I have watched them go for sixty years and never once thought anything about it.

He looks past Manu, at the black hill above the village.

KIATO When I was a boy that hill was trees to the top. We ate it. We ate the whole island, and we are still hungry. Four months of what? What do we eat while we wait for your birds?

Nobody answers.

KIATO You have the canoe. You sail on the next moon.

MANU The next moon is winter. Nothing will be flying. If I go now I've got nothing to steer by but what I've worked out from the cords.

KIATO Then be right.

Manu's head comes up. He looks at Hina. She does not look at him.

KIATO Tamatoa commands. It is the sacred canoe and it goes out under the war chief or it does not go.

Tamatoa, who has stood through all of this with his face closed, opens it very slightly.

KIATO My daughter goes as his wife. If there is land, the line goes to it.

Hina's hands, in her lap, do not move.

KIATO Tihoti goes as priest. Someone has to bury them.

He stands. He is done. The elders stand.

KIATO *(to Manu, not unkindly)* Pick up your stones.

He goes. The marae empties around Manu, who is on his knees among his pebbles, picking them up one at a time and setting them in his palm, in order, so that he will know which was which.

Tamatoa is the last to go. He stands over his brother.

TAMATOA So it's winter.

MANU Yes.

TAMATOA And there are no birds.

MANU No.

Tamatoa considers him.

TAMATOA Then it's just you.

He picks up his club and goes.

EXT. VILLAGE PATH — LATER THAT NIGHT

Manu walks home with the bundle of stones against his chest. The torches are out and the village is asleep, or pretending to be.

Ahead of him on the path is a figure, and it is Hina, walking away from him toward the far end of the village.

He slows. Opens his mouth to call to her, and does not, because she is walking like someone who does not want to be seen walking.

She reaches a house on a high platform, Tamatoa's house, and stands at the foot of the steps for the length of a breath.

Then she goes up, and in.

Manu stands on the path with the stones against his chest. He does not move for a long time.

Then he goes home.

INT. TAMATOA'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

It is dark. Tamatoa is sitting up on his mat with the club within reach, because that is how he sleeps.

Hina stands in the doorway.

He looks at her. He does not ask anything. She does not say anything.

She comes in.

EXT. BEACH — DAY (DAYS LATER)

The whole village on Te Ivi, and the work is rope.

Men sit in a line on the sand with coconut fibre across their thighs, rolling it into cord with the flat of the hand, one long stroke down the leg, over and over, without looking, the way they have done it since they were boys. The cord piles up beside each of them like something growing. Behind them, other men lash it: hull to crossbeam, crossbeam to deck,

a thousand turns, each one hauled tight with a foot against the wood.

Women at the top of the beach plaiting pandanus leaf into sail, strip over strip, the sail lying on the sand the length of the canoe, getting longer.

Akau, rolling cord like everyone else, beside Manu, who is rolling it badly.

AKAU Roll it down, not across. You're twisting it the wrong way.

MANU It's rope.

AKAU It's the rope that holds the mast. When it goes, everything goes.

Manu rolls it down, and it is still bad. Akau takes it off his thigh, unrolls it, and does it again himself without a word.

KOA, twelve years old, thin and serious, is at the water's edge, filling a wooden trough with wet moss from the stream, packing it, laying breadfruit shoots into it one at a time, roots down, with the care of a boy who has been told his life depends on it and believes it.

EXT. THE REEF FLAT — NIGHT

It is low tide, and the reef flat is exposed for half a mile, with black water in the pools and, out across it, torches: men wading with spears, fishing by the light.

Tamatoa and Roa, thigh-deep, a torch in Roa's hand and a three-pronged spear in Tamatoa's. Tamatoa is looking at the water and not at Roa, and the spear goes in without warning and comes up with a fish on it, and he strips it into the basket at his hip and goes on looking.

ROA (*quiet*) And if he's wrong?

TAMATOA Then he dies out there, and I call him a hero, and I bring the canoe home.

The spear goes in and misses. He waits.

ROA And if he's right?

TAMATOA Then I step off first.

The spear goes in and comes up with a fish, and the fish goes into the basket.

Roa moves the torch. Beyond the edge of the reef flat, past the last of the torches, the water goes from black to a different black, and the swell moves in it, and there is no bottom.

ROA You've never been out past —

TAMATOA I know where I've been.

He wades on along the reef edge, away from the deep water, and Roa brings the torch after

him.

INT. MANU'S MOTHER'S HOUSE — NIGHT (THE NIGHT BEFORE THE CANOE SAILS)

A small house at the edge of the village, below the good platforms. A fire of coconut husk, which burns low and smells sweet and gives almost no light. MANU'S MOTHER, fifties, the lesser wife.

She has his stones. She is wrapping them in a cloth, in their order, without being told the order, and tying the bundle with a cord.

The knot she ties has a turn in it that no one else on the island ties.

Manu watches her hands.

MANU That's his knot.

MOTHER Everything he tied, he tied like that. The house, the canoe, your cradle.

She pulls it tight.

MOTHER He didn't look at you until you were three. He'd come to my fire and talk about the birds and never once look at the child on the mat. Then one morning you counted the flock off his fingers, and after that he never looked at anything else.

MANU I don't remember that.

MOTHER No. You were three. I do.

MOTHER You do it too. You don't know you do.

He looks at his own hands.

MOTHER If you ever see it on a thing, you'll know he touched it.

MANU I won't see it.

MOTHER No.

She gives him the bundle. She does not hold him. She is a woman who was never given much and learned early not to ask.

MOTHER He went before light so he wouldn't have to say it. Say it.

Manu stands with the stones against his chest.

MANU Goodbye.

MOTHER There. That's more than I got.

She turns back to the fire. He goes.

CUT TO:

EXT. BEACH — PRE-DAWN (WINTER)

It is grey and cold for this place, with a wind off the land.

TE IVI, the sacred canoe, sits on rollers at the top of the beach: two hulls the length of a house, planks sewn edge to edge with coconut cord, seams packed black with breadfruit sap; a deck lashed between; a mast in a carved step; a crab-claw sail furled along its boom. Rope holds all of it together and nothing else does. Every lashing is new. It has not been in the water in a generation.

Around it, the whole village, moving things.

There are pigs, tied by the legs and complaining, and dogs, and chickens in baskets. There are taro corms wrapped in leaf, breadfruit shoots standing in wet moss in a wooden trough, sprouted coconuts, bundles of paper mulberry, and kava root wrapped in wet leaf, for the priest and for whatever ceremonies a new land turns out to need. And there are gourds, dozens of them, the dried shells of the bottle-vine, stoppered with wood and full of water, lashed in rows under the deck.

At the water's edge, Tamatoa stands apart, looking at the reef, and the white line where the swell breaks on it, and the grey beyond it that goes on until it stops being a colour. Roa comes and stands beside him and does not say anything.

After a while Tamatoa turns and walks up the beach to the canoe. Roa looks at the grey a moment longer, and follows.

EXT. BEACH — CONTINUOUS

Manu at the trough of cuttings with Koa. The boy was chosen over his mother; there was room for one of them this time, and she chose him. She is on the sand behind him, and he has not looked at her since he was told.

KOA How much water do they get?

Manu is not looking at the cuttings. He is looking at the sky over the reef, where the last stars are going.

MANU It's fourteen days, with twenty-four mouths at a gourd each a day, and we carry twenty days of it.

KOA They're not mouths.

MANU Hm?

KOA The cuttings aren't mouths. And they don't know it's fourteen days.

Manu does not hear him. He has seen something in the sky and is turning to face it, one hand coming up to fix its place.

Koa looks at the trough, and then at Manu's back.

VAEA, twenties, sun-dark, a planter's hands, has been watching from the next pile of cargo. She comes over and puts one of the gourds into the boy's arms.

VAEA This one's for the plants. Don't tell him it's gone.

Koa holds it like a thing that might be taken away.

EXT. BEACH — CONTINUOUS

Near the water, on a flat stone, AKAU, twenties, has laid out his tools: bone combs, needles of bird bone, a mallet, a shell of black pigment. His own hands are black to the second knuckle with it.

He sits behind them and waits.

AKAU (*to anyone*) I'll put the star points on your arm before we go.

People walk past him with pigs.

AKAU It won't wash off and it can't go over the side. If anything happens to the navigator, the route is still on somebody's arm.

A warrior laughs, not cruelly, and keeps walking.

AKAU (*to Manu, who is passing with a coil of cord*) Navigator.

Manu does not stop. He does not look. He is counting the gourds under the deck.

Akau watches him go. Then he wraps his tools in their cloth, one at a time, and carries them aboard.

EXT. BEACH — CONTINUOUS

Moeata comes down the sand with a net over one shoulder and nothing else. She walks to the canoe and puts a hand on the hull.

A warrior at the rail looks at her, and then up the beach for someone to ask.

MOEATA I asked the Chief. He said yes.

WARRIOR Why?

MOEATA Someone has to know what the sea is doing when he stops looking.

She climbs aboard before anyone can decide about it.

EXT. BEACH — DAWN

The canoe is loaded, with twenty-four people aboard out of the four hundred on the island, standing, sitting, holding children. The young men are in loincloths. The women are rubbed yellow with turmeric, so that the beach smells of it, and wear the last flowers on the island, which will be brown by noon. A girl of five in a headdress of two dried leaves stands very still at the water's edge to be looked at. There are two infants, one asleep and one not.

Tihoti walks the hulls with a torch.

He starts at the stern of the port hull and walks forward, slowly, and as he walks he sings, and the singing is the canoe: the tree it was cut from, the man who cut it, the valley the tree stood in, the year, and then the hull, and then the lashings and the vine they were made from.

The village on the sand goes silent for it.

He reaches the bow and crosses to the other hull and comes back. Then he stands in the centre of the deck and sings the crew, one by one. Each name, and the name's parents, and theirs. He does not hurry. A child begins to cry and is fed. The torch burns down and is replaced.

When he reaches Hina's name he stops. She takes it up herself: her own line, her father, his father, back. She is standing at Tamatoa's side to sing it. Manu, at the sweep, keeps his eyes on the reef the whole time she sings. His knuckles on the sweep go white, and stay white. When she finishes, Tihoti goes on.

He does not sing Manu's line. He sings the father's name and then Manu's, and the father's name is on the cord across his arm, and he touches it as he sings it.

It takes an hour. No one is bored.

Kiato stands at the water's edge with his hands behind his back. When it is done, he raises one hand, and the men on the sand put their shoulders to the rollers.

EXT. THE REEF — CONTINUOUS

Te Ivi slides. The bows lift on the first swell inside the lagoon.

Tihoti, at the deck's centre, has the pahu between his knees, the tall drum lashed there for this. He strikes it. Paddles go in, forty at once, on the beat, and a chant goes with them, called by one voice and answered by forty, because forty paddles will not go in together any other way.

From the point of the reef, a conch shell, blown by someone on the rocks, one long note, until the canoe is through.

The gap in the reef ahead. White on both sides, a lane of green between.

Manu is at the steering sweep, the long oar at the stern that turns the canoe. He has never held it on this canoe. His hands know it anyway.

The beach behind them is full of birds. Plovers, hundreds, fat, wintering, walking on the wet sand where the canoe was, taking no interest in anything.

Manu looks back at them once.

Tamatoa, in the bow with his club, does not look back. He is looking at Manu.

The canoe goes through the gap. The first open swell takes her, and the deck tilts, and someone's child laughs.

Behind them, on the sand, Kiato does not move until the sail is small. Apart from the crowd, at the water's edge, Manu's mother stands where she stood fifteen years ago, and watches a second sail go the way the first one went.

EXT. THE SEA — FROM HIGH ABOVE — CONTINUOUS

From the height of a bird. The island, green and black, and its ring of white, and outside the ring, on the whole blue face of the water, one speck with a sail, going north. Nothing else, to any edge.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 1

Everything is blue, with no land in any direction, and none of them has ever seen that.

The sail is up and full. The hulls hiss. The long trade-wind swell comes under them from the east and lifts and sets them down, lifts and sets them down, like breathing. The hulls creak on the lift and slap on the fall, and a gourd hung from the boom swings once each time, and by the end of the first day nobody aboard hears any of it.

The crew are quiet in the way of people who have been frightened and are now, against their will, happy. Dried fish comes round, and a coconut opened with the adze, and the milk goes down the line, one mouthful each.

Koa at the trough, wetting the moss with his fingers.

Bodies on the deck, brown and salt-streaked, the young men asleep in the sun the way they never could ashore.

Vaea at the rail with her face in the wind.

Hina in the stern, on her heels, singing under her breath. Not a chant that exists. She is putting the reef into it, and the gap, and the birds on the sand. She is making the crossing into something that can be sung.

Manu at the sweep, looking at the sun's shadow on the deck, and then at the swell, and then at the shadow.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT 1

The sky is above them, and every star, all the way down to the water on every side. Nothing like it has ever been seen by anyone aboard, because there has always been an island in the way.

The wake burns. Green fire in the water behind the hulls, every paddle-stroke lighting as it goes in, a fish passing under the canoe lit up like a lamp. The sea is so flat that the stars are in it too, above the canoe and below it.

Nobody speaks.

At the bow a woman is standing. She is dancing without moving her feet: the hands only, turning, the old dance for calm water, and nobody asked her to, and nobody is watching her but the children, and the children are not making a sound.

Somewhere aft, Akau with a nose flute, a length of bamboo held to one nostril, three notes and a fourth, over and over, small against all that sky, and the hull creaking under it in time.

Manu on his back on the deck, eyes open, lips moving. His hand rises and points, and moves, and points.

He looks north, low, where the birds would be if it were spring.

There is nothing there, only stars down to the water, and no wings.

He looks for a long time.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 3

The third day, and then the fourth.

Moeata lies in the bilge of the port hull, flat on her back on the wet planks, arms out, eyes shut. She has been there since dawn. Children step over her.

Manu comes down into the hull for a gourd.

MOEATA (*eyes shut*) The current's taking us west.

MANU I know it is. I measured it off the reef for three years. It sets us west two fingers a day, and that's in every line I've drawn.

MOEATA That was the reef's water. This isn't the reef.

MANU It's the same sea.

MOEATA It's more out here. I can feel that it's more.

He takes the gourd. He stands there with it. He is not unkind about it.

MANU I can't put a feeling on a cord.

MOEATA Then lie down here and feel it yourself.

MANU I'll watch for it.

MOEATA You'll watch, and you won't see it. It isn't up there.

He goes back on deck.

She stays where she is, flat on the planks, feeling the sea come through the wood.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT 5

Something hits the deck, and then another does: a slap, a flutter, a slap.

Flying fish, drawn by the lamp, coming aboard on their own. The sleepers wake to fish landing on them. A child shrieks with joy. Roa is on his feet grabbing them out of the air like a man catching thrown fruit.

Koa is on his knees collecting them, six, then eight, and he does not know what to do with them.

Moeata, sitting up in the hull hatch, holds out her hand. He gives her one. She takes a thumbnail down its belly, hooks, pulls, and it is clean, and she hands it back.

MOEATA Eat it.

KOA Raw?

MOEATA It's already dead. What else do you want to do to it?

He eats it. His face does several things.

MOEATA Now do the next one. Put your thumb there, and don't dig, just pull.

He does it badly, and then less badly. She watches his hands and not his face, the way she watched the water and not Manu.

MOEATA That one's torn. Give it to the pig.

KOA Manu says the pigs get nothing till land.

MOEATA Manu's never gutted a fish.

KOA He knows more than anyone.

MOEATA About some things.

She takes the next fish out of his hands and does it herself, in one movement, and gives it to the child who shrieked. The torn one she drops in front of the pig without looking at anyone.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT — LATER

It is the late watch and the sail is drawing. The rest of the canoe is asleep, a landscape of bodies under mats, with fish scales everywhere.

Manu is at the sweep. Tihoti sits on the deck beside him with the cord across his knees, looking up.

Neither has spoken for a long time.

TIHOTI You read it like a cord.

MANU What?

TIHOTI I mean the sea. You read it.

MANU The swell bends around land, and you feel it before you see it. Birds fly to land. Stars come up where they always come up, every night. It can be read. That's all it is.

TIHOTI A body can be read.

Manu does not follow.

TIHOTI I could read my mother's body. I could tell where she had walked by her feet, and what she had eaten by her breath, and I knew when she was sick. I read her very well for forty years.

He touches his own forearm, the old ink.

TIHOTI I could read her, and she was still my mother. You can read the sea, and it is still what it is.

Manu waits.

TIHOTI You have been lying on its back for five nights, and you have not asked whose it is.

MANU I never asked the reef whose it was either, and I've read the reef since I was six.

He nods at the sky.

TIHOTI They have.

Manu is quiet. Then, carefully, because he wants to know and not because he is arguing:

MANU Then what does it want?

Tihoti looks at him, and for once he is not arguing.

TIHOTI To be spoken to.

TIHOTI You have never once spoken to it. I've listened for it, and there hasn't been a word.

Manu says nothing. He looks at the water going past the hull, black, with the stars in it.

Tihoti gets up, and goes to the rail, and tells the sea who is aboard tonight, too low for anyone but the sea to hear, the way he does every night, and then goes to sleep.

Manu stays at the sweep and looks at the water for a long time, and says nothing.

CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT 11

It is calm, the sail full and silent, and the whole canoe is asleep except the sweep.

A dog asleep with its head on a warrior's leg, and the warrior's hand on the dog. The two infants fed and quiet, one on the old woman, one on Vaea, who did not want it and has it. Roa on the half of the mat that is his. Koa curled round the trough with his arm over it. Tamatoa, in the bow, asleep for once, his face turned up, the club under his hand, and for as long as he sleeps he is a man of thirty with a cut over his eye and nothing else.

Hina at the stern, awake, singing under her breath to no one, the crossing so far.

The stars go down to the water on every side, and the hull lifts and sets down, lifts and sets down, and for the length of this scene there is nothing wrong anywhere.

Manu at the sweep, looking at all of it.

Then he looks south.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT — LATER

Manu is at the sweep, and the sky behind him, to the south, comes down low over the water.

Three stars close together, just above the sea: the ones Hina's chant calls the three sisters, the ones he called the three. He is watching them the way you watch a fire going out.

Tihoti is awake. He has seen where Manu is looking.

TIHOTI How long?

MANU They should have gone under two nights ago.

TIHOTI Should have.

MANU We're slower than I worked out.

He says it to himself more than to the priest. Tihoti hears it anyway, and says nothing, and looks at the sisters.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT — LATER

The whole crew awake now, on deck, facing south. Word has gone round.

The three stars touch the water. One goes, and then the second, and the third hangs for a long moment on the edge of the sea, and then it is not there.

A sound comes from the crew, not a cry but something lower.

A woman with an infant turns the child's face to the south, as if it should see.

TIHOTI (*standing*) Sit down.

They sit. He walks among them with a shell blade.

TIHOTI They were the sisters who stood on the bow of the first canoe. They are the first of us to go under. They will not be the last.

He takes a lock of his own hair and cuts it and holds it over the side, and lets the wind take it.

TIHOTI (*sung*) The three sisters, who stood on the bow of Te Ivi, who were born of the sky...

He goes along the deck. Each of them, one by one, gives him a lock of hair, and he puts it into the water, and sings the sisters' line as if it were a dead woman's line: where they came from, who they stood beside, what they did.

When he reaches Tamatoa, the war chief hesitates, and then bows his head, and Tihoti cuts. Tamatoa's eyes stay on the black water where the hair goes.

When he reaches Manu, Manu is looking north.

TIHOTI Navigator.

Manu turns. Tihoti waits. Manu bends his head and Tihoti cuts.

TIHOTI (*low, for him only*) You've been counting them as they go. So have I, in my way. Neither of us has missed one.

He moves on.

Hina at the stern, not weeping, singing under her breath. She is putting the sisters into the chant of the crossing: the night, the three lights going under, the hair on the water. She is already making this into a chant.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 13

An ordinary day.

Akau, with the old woman's hand in his lap, is putting a small flower on the back of it with the needle, because she asked, and because there is nothing else to do. She does not flinch. Her grandchild watches the black go in and wants one too.

Vaea and Roa, on the same mat, an argument about the mat. It has been going on since the reef. Neither has raised a voice.

VAEA You're on my half.

ROA There's no half to a mat.

VAEA There is, and this is it.

Roa moves a hand's width. She looks at the hand's width.

The old woman's grandchild is at the breast of a woman who is not its mother, because its mother's milk has gone. At the stern, three women sit with Hina, talking low, and one of them counts mornings on her fingers and stops at seven.

Two of the younger warriors scratching a game into the deck with a shell and playing it with pebbles that Manu, at the sweep, has been trying not to look at, because they are his.

A pig, tied by the legs, has worked its snout into Koa's trough and is eating the wet moss off the cuttings. Koa catches it, hits it, and then gives it a coconut husk. It eats the husk.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHTS — MONTAGE

The southern sky, night by night, losing stars.

The net, the eel, and the old woman's fire go the same way, each one lower each night, each one touching the water, each one gone. Each time Tihoti sings it under, and the crew sit for it, and hair goes in the water.

By the fifth night no one has much hair left to give. They give it anyway.

Manu, at the sweep each night, sees them go and moves his hand a little in the air each time, fixing the place where they were.

The north is filling up with stars that never rose above Nuku Hiva, the far northern ones, and he does not have names for them. He points, and moves, and points.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT 17

It is late and the crew are asleep. Manu is at the sweep.

Hina comes aft along the deck, stepping over sleepers, and sits down on the crossbeam a body's length from him, and no closer.

Neither speaks. Then Manu reaches across the gap.

She does not take his hand. She looks at it.

HINA Not here.

MANU There's no one —

HINA He's awake. He's been awake every night since the reef. He lies in the bow and he watches.

Manu takes his hand back.

HINA He doesn't watch you. He knows where you are. He watches me, to see where I'm looking.

MANU Where are you looking?

She does not answer. She looks at the water.

Then, low, not turning to him, she sings, and it is not the old chant but the new one: the reef, and the gap, and the birds on the sand going nowhere; the first night with no island in the way; the sisters going under, and the hair on the water. It is the crossing, as far as it has gone.

His name is in it.

She finishes. She stands.

HINA That's yours. No one else has heard it.

She goes forward, stepping over the sleepers.

In the bow, Tamatoa's eyes are open. They were open the whole time. He heard a woman singing, low, at the stern. He does not know what she sang.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT 20 — WELL NORTH OF THE LINE

It is late and most of the crew are asleep. Manu is at the sweep, with Koa awake beside him because the boy cannot sleep and has stopped pretending.

Manu is looking north, low.

There is a small star there, not bright. It has come up over the sea in the last few nights and he has not paid it much attention.

Now he is paying attention.

MANU (*quiet*) Koa. Watch that one.

KOA Which?

MANU The small one, low, just there. Watch it.

They watch it, and time passes. The sail creaks, and somewhere a pig shifts.

KOA It's not moving.

MANU It's moving.

KOA It's not going up.

MANU No.

KOA Everything goes up.

MANU Yes.

He gets up from the sweep. Hands it to the boy without thinking, which he has never done. Koa takes it.

Manu goes to the bow and lies on his back on the deck and looks straight up, and then north, and then up.

The star is turning in a tight circle, very slowly, around a point of black sky where there is nothing.

What they are seeing is the pole of the sky, the point the whole sky turns on. In this century there is no star on it; the small one circling it is the star that will, in a few hundred years, drift onto it and be called the north star. Tonight it is just a star going round a hole.

And the stars beside it turn around that same point in a wider ring. And the ones beyond those, wider. The whole sky is going round. It is going round a hole.

Manu's hand comes up and finds the centre of the hole and stays there.

He is weeping. He does not seem to know it.

KOA (*from the sweep, frightened*) Manu.

Manu does not answer.

KOA Manu. What is it?

MANU It hangs from a point.

He says it to the sky.

MANU The whole sky hangs from one point and turns round it, like a net hung on a peg. And there's nothing on the peg. Everything turns around a place where there's nothing.

He laughs, once, wet.

MANU He never told me. He can't have known, or he'd have said.

By now others are awake: Tamatoa, and Hina, and Tihoti with the cord.

They look where he is pointing. They see it: the small star going round, and the sky going round with it.

There is a murmur, and then it is more than a murmur.

A WOMAN Priest. What is it?

Tihoti looks. He looks for a long time. His lips move. He is going through the names, all of them, everything he has.

TIHOTI I don't know.

THE WOMAN What is its name?

TIHOTI Everything in the sky has a mother. The sisters, the net, the eel: I can sing you every one of them back to the first canoe.

He looks at Manu on his back on the deck, with his hand up in the air.

TIHOTI That one has no mother. I don't know who made it, and I won't name it.

He sits down. He does not sing anything. There is nothing to sing.

The crew look at the hole. Then, one by one, they look at the man lying under it with his hand raised, who has been steering them toward it for twenty nights and is now crying with joy.

Tamatoa watches Manu. Then he looks at the crew watching Manu.

He goes back to the bow. He sits down facing the crew instead of the sea, and he stays that way till morning.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 21

At dawn the sail stopped drawing. It hangs, fills weakly, empties, and hangs again, and by the middle of the morning it has stopped doing even that.

The sea is flat, without a swell or a ripple. It is a sheet of hot metal to every horizon and the sky is the same sheet turned over. There is no line between them.

The canoe sits in the middle of it with the sail hanging like something dead.

The heat is a weight. It presses people flat to the deck. Children do not cry. They do not have the water for it.

Manu on his knees at the sweep with a cord across his thighs, counting knots, lips moving.

MANU (*under his breath*) Twenty-one.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

The gourds stand in a row under the deck, and most of the row is empty. Roa is going along it, lifting each and shaking it, listening.

He looks up at Tamatoa. He does not need to say the number.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

The paddles go in slowly, and the canoe creeps.

Manu at the sweep with his eyes on the sun's shadow, holding the line.

Moeata is at the rail. She is not looking at the sun. She is looking south-west, low, where the sky is a different grey.

MOEATA There.

Nobody turns.

MOEATA (*louder*) There.

They turn.

Far off to the south-west there is a dark patch under a cloud, with a grey veil hanging from it to the sea.

MOEATA Rain.

TAMATOA How far?

MOEATA Half a day, if we paddle at it.

TAMATOA Turn the canoe.

MANU No.

Tamatoa is already at the sweep. Manu does not let go of it.

MANU It's south of us, behind us. Half a day there and half a day back, and we've lost the line. That's two days.

TAMATOA You don't have two days of water.

MANU We're close. I've worked it out.

MOEATA You've worked it out.

She says it without heat.

MOEATA I've followed rain my whole life. It's there, and it's water. Turn the canoe.

MANU And the line?

MOEATA Find it again.

MANU I can't find it again. I'm not steering by birds. I'm steering by where I've been. If I leave it I'm —

He stops. He will not say the word in front of them.

Tamatoa's hand is on the sweep next to Manu's. The crew are watching the two hands.

Hina stands.

HINA How close?

Manu looks at her.

MANU Six days.

She holds his eyes. Then she turns to the crew.

HINA Six days, then. We go on.

Tamatoa's eyes go from Hina to the crew. Every face on the deck is on her. She has never, before this, stood beside Manu where anyone could see her do it.

Tamatoa takes his hand off the sweep.

Tihoti strikes the drum. The paddles go in again, on the beat, and the chant with them, thin, and the canoe creeps north.

Behind them, the grey veil hangs from its cloud, and then, very slowly, the cloud moves off west, and the veil goes with it, and there is nothing there.

Moeata watches it until it is gone. Then she goes down into the hull and lies on the planks.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

Tamatoa is at the gourds, with Roa beside him.

TAMATOA Every gourd goes here, under Roa. No one drinks unless I say.

He looks at the crew. Nobody argues. There is nothing left to argue with.

TAMATOA *(to Roa, low)* Your wife drinks. That's the arrangement.

ROA That was always the arrangement.

Roa goes along the deck with a gourd. He gives Vaea, his wife, a mouthful. She looks at him as she drinks and then at the woman beside her, who does not get one.

Tamatoa stops at the trough of cuttings.

TAMATOA Those too.

KOA No.

The boy is standing between Tamatoa and the trough.

TAMATOA Move.

KOA They die in a day without it, and we don't.

Tamatoa hits him. Open-handed, not hard, the way you cuff a dog, and the boy goes down on the deck.

Vaea is between them before Tamatoa can bend for the trough. She does not say anything. She stands there. She is a planter with a dry mouth, and she is between the war chief and a trough of breadfruit shoots, and she does not move.

Tamatoa looks at her, and then at Roa.

Roa does not move either.

Tamatoa leaves the trough. He goes back to the bow and sits down with the club across his knees.

INT. HULL — DUSK

Moeata lies on the planks. Koa comes down with the mouthful Roa has allowed him, in a shell.

She opens her eyes.

MOEATA Put it in the trough.

KOA It's yours.

MOEATA Put it in the trough. I've had mine.

She has not. He knows she has not. He takes the shell up on deck and pours it into the moss.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 23

Manu is at the sweep with the cord.

MANU (*under his breath*) Twenty-three.

INT. HULL — DAWN

Moeata on the planks, flat, arms out, eyes shut, the way she lies to listen.

Koa comes down. He stands over her.

KOA Moeata.

She does not answer. He crouches. He puts a hand on her arm, and takes it away.

He does not cry. He goes up on deck and finds Tihoti, and does not have to say anything.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — MORNING

They lift her out of the hull on a mat. She weighs nothing.

Tihoti stands over her and sings. Her line: her mother, her mother's mother, the net-makers, back to the woman who came in the canoe. It is not long. She was not from a great house.

When he finishes, he takes the cord from his arm and ties a knot in it, the first.

Then Roa and another man tip the mat, and she goes over the side, and the flat sea takes her without a sound.

Hina, at the stern, singing under her breath, puts Moeata's name into the chant of the crossing.

Manu has not moved from the sweep. He did not sing. He did not look at the water when she went in. He is looking at the sun's shadow on the deck, holding the line.

Koa comes and stands in front of him with the empty shell in his hand, and stays there, and Manu keeps his eyes on the shadow. After a while Vaea takes the boy away.

Nobody comes near the sweep for the rest of the day. The paddles go in without the drum. Tihoti does not strike it, and nobody asks him to.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT

It is black, with no stars; something has come over the sky from behind them.

Then comes the sound, a hiss getting louder, coming across the water from the south-west.

It is rain.

It hits the canoe like a thrown thing, warm and heavy and straight down. The crew are up and screaming, faces turned to it, mouths open, holding out mats and gourds and hands. Koa has the trough tipped to it. Roa is laughing, and Vaea is not.

Manu stands in it at the sweep.

The water runs down his face and off his chin. He does not turn his face up. He does not open his mouth.

It has come from the south-west, from where she said it would.

He looks at the crew drinking. He looks at the empty place at the rail where she stood and said *there*.

He cannot look at anyone. He looks at the sweep in his hands.

The rain goes on.

CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAWN, DAY 27

There is wind again, light, from the east, and the sail is full and the hulls are moving.

Manu at the sweep, the cord across his knees. He has not slept. The last knot on the cord is under his thumb, and beyond it there is no cord.

MANU (*to himself*) Twenty-seven.

He looks north.

The horizon is clean, with nothing on it.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY

The whole crew on deck, standing, facing north. No one has told them to. They know what day it is.

The sky is empty, with no birds, no cloud standing still over a place, and no weed in the water. It is blue to the edge, all the way round.

EXT. THE SEA — FROM HIGH ABOVE — CONTINUOUS

From the height of a bird, the sea is blue to every edge, with a speck in the middle of it that

is not moving. From here there is something the speck cannot see: far to the north-east, at the very rim, a cloud that is standing still.

Koa at the bow, shading his eyes, looking harder than anyone, because he is the one who wants it most.

There is nothing.

Manu is at the sweep. He has the cord in his hands and is running it through his fingers from the beginning, fast, lips moving, as if the answer might be a knot he skipped.

Nobody looks at him.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

Tamatoa stands in the centre of the deck. He does not raise his voice. He has never needed to.

TAMATOA By what he worked out, this is the beach.

He waits. He lets them look at the water where the beach is.

TAMATOA I count too. It's been twenty-seven days. We left the reef with twenty days of water, and I can lift what's left with one hand. One of us is dead. She said turn, and he said six days. This is the sixth.

He turns to Tihoti.

TAMATOA Priest, what is owed?

Tihoti has been sitting with the cord across his knees since dawn. He looks at the water, and then at Manu, and then at the crew, who are looking at him now, all of them, because a war chief can kill a man and a priest can make it right.

TIHOTI What is owed is what was taken.

He stands.

TIHOTI For fifteen springs the birds went out over its back, and he counted them and said nothing to it. Fifteen springs of its birds, on cords.

He looks at Manu.

TIHOTI It will have the cords. And then it will have the man who tied them, so that it knows whose they were.

Nobody objects, not Koa, not Vaea, and not Hina.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

Manu is seated at the bow, facing forward, with two men behind him. They have not bound him. He has not tried to move.

Tihoti beside him with the cords. All of them, the whole bundle from the ridge. He takes the first and holds it over the water.

TIHOTI (*sung*) The first spring. The birds went north, and he counted them, and they came back, and he counted them.

He lets the cord go. It lies on the water for a moment, dark, and then the wet takes it and it goes under.

Manu watches it go under.

TIHOTI (*sung*) The second spring...

The second cord goes in.

It goes on, fifteen cords for fifteen springs, each one sung, each one dropped, each one lying on the surface for the length of a breath and then gone.

Manu does not close his eyes. He watches every one. His face does nothing. By the eighth cord his hands are open on his knees and not moving.

The crew watch too. Some of them have their heads bowed. Koa is not looking at the water. He is looking at Manu.

TIHOTI (*sung*) The fifteenth spring, and he was under the birds with his stones, and he put the last knot on the last cord...

The last cord goes in.

Tihoti's voice changes. It is the verse for a man.

TIHOTI (*sung*) Manu, son of the navigator, whose name is on my arm —

HINA Stop.

She is standing. She has come forward through the crew and she is standing in front of Tamatoa, not Tihoti.

HINA I'm carrying your child.

The verse stops. Everything stops.

HINA I've been sick seven mornings. Ask the women; they've counted with me. I spent one night in your house, the night of the council. Ask anyone on this canoe who saw me go up the steps.

Tamatoa's face does nothing at all.

HINA It's yours, and it's the Chief's line in a new land. That's what you sailed for.

She turns, now, to the crew.

HINA And there is one man on this canoe who can put it on the ground, and you're about to give him to the water.

She turns back.

HINA Give the sea something else.

A long silence, with only the sail and the water.

Tamatoa looks at her. Then at the women, and one of them nods. Then at the crew who saw her go up his steps, and nobody looks away. He looks for a long time, the way he looks for a lie, and there is none in anything she said.

His face changes.

TAMATOA *(to Tihoti)* Sit down.

Tihoti does not move.

TAMATOA Sit down, priest. The sea's had the cords.

Tihoti sits. He puts the empty hand that held the cords on his knee and looks at it.

Manu, at the bow, has turned. He is looking at Hina.

He looks at her, and at her belly, where there is nothing to see yet, and at Tamatoa, and at the water, where fifteen years of cords have just gone, and back at her.

His mouth opens. She gives him the smallest shake of the head there is. He closes it.

Hina holds his eyes one moment longer. Then she goes to the stern, and sits down with her back to the canoe, and does not turn round for the rest of the day.

Tamatoa has watched her go. Now he looks at Manu.

TAMATOA Two days.

He goes to the bow. He does not speak to anyone for the rest of the day.

INT. HULL — NIGHT

The port hull, with its wet planks, is the place where Moeata lay.

Manu climbs down into it. He stands there. Then he lies down, flat on his back, arms out, the

way she lay.

He shuts his eyes.

There is nothing, only the hull creaking and water slapping and the sound of twenty-three people breathing in their sleep.

He stays.

The long swell comes under the hull from the east and lifts it and sets it down. Lifts it and sets it down. It has been under him for twenty-seven days and he has never once paid attention to it.

He is paying attention now.

It lifts, and sets down, and lifts.

And something is wrong with it. It has been under him for twenty-seven days and it has never once been wrong. Now the lift is weaker than the fall. The breath is ragged. It comes, and stutters, and comes short, as if something were standing in front of the wind.

He opens his eyes.

Above him, through the hatch, the gourd on the boom is swinging, not in a line but in a shape.

He lies there and feels it again, and again. The wind is east, and steady. The swell that wind has been making for twenty-seven days is coming apart under him, and a swell does not come apart in open water. It comes apart in the lee of something, and something large.

MOEATA (V.O.) It's more out here. I can feel that it's more.

It is not a voice but the memory of one, flat on the planks, with her eyes shut.

MOEATA (V.O.) Then lie down here and feel it yourself.

Manu puts both palms flat on the wet wood.

They have gone west, twenty-seven days of more west than the reef's number, a little every day, under a line he checked in the sky every night and never once in the water. The beach is not ahead of them. It never was. It is upwind, north-east, in whatever is standing in front of the wind, and they have sailed into its shadow in the dark with a dead woman telling them so.

He lies there until dawn, feeling the long swell come in broken, and it does not mend.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAWN

The sea at first light, from very low, backlit. The long swell coming from the east, and it is

not the clean line it has been for twenty-seven days. It is ragged, flattened, confused: the water of a lee.

Manu comes up out of the hull. The crew are already awake. They watch him come.

He does not go to the sweep. He stands on the deck in the middle of them, where Tamatoa stood yesterday.

He does not say *I've found it*. He does not say *I was right*.

MANU On the third day out, Moeata told me the current was more than I'd allowed for.

They wait.

MANU I'd measured it at the reef for three years and put it in every line, and I told her that. She said this wasn't the reef. I said I'd watch for it, and then I checked the sky every night and never once checked the water, because I don't know how, and she did.

He looks at Koa.

MANU She's dead because I didn't listen to her. There was nothing wrong with the numbers. It was me.

Nobody says anything. Vaea, who had her arms folded, unfolds them.

MANU The long swell's broken. It's been under us since the reef, and last night it came in wrong and ragged. A swell doesn't break up in open water; it breaks up in the lee of land. She'd have told you that on the first day.

He points north-east, and it is not the angle his father showed him.

MANU I think the land is there, upwind. I don't know how far, because a shadow that size could reach a long way, and I'd never felt a swell before last night. She'd have known how far.

He stops.

MANU We can't go back. Home is twenty-seven days behind us and we have five gourds. Whatever we do, we do it on five gourds, and the land is closer than home if it's there at all. I'm not telling you. I'm asking you. It's your water.

There is a silence, with the sail, and the morning light coming up.

Vaea looks at Roa. Roa looks at the gourds. Koa is looking at the north-east as if he could see through it.

Hina, at the stern, has turned round.

Tamatoa stands up in the bow.

He looks at his brother for a long moment.

TAMATOA Two days.

MANU You said that yesterday.

TAMATOA Yesterday it meant two days and then I'd kill you. Turn the canoe.

He sits back down.

TAMATOA Turn the canoe.

Manu goes to the sweep. Koa is there before him and gives it up, and Manu turns Te Ivi's bow away from the line his father drew, toward the place a dead woman felt in the planks.

The crew do not cheer. But they go to the paddles, and nobody told them to.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT

It is late, on the new heading, and the small star is turning in its circle to the north, off the port bow now instead of dead ahead.

Tihoti is at the rail, speaking to the water quietly and steadily, the way a man speaks to someone in the next room. He is not chanting; he is talking.

Manu at the sweep, watching him.

Tihoti finishes. He goes to his mat and lies down.

Manu looks at the water for a long time.

Then he leaves the sweep, and goes to the rail, and stands where Tihoti stood.

He opens his mouth.

Nothing comes. He looks over his shoulder. No one is watching. Tihoti, on his mat, has his eyes shut, and is not asleep.

He looks back at the water.

MANU (*barely sound*) I don't know what you are.

The water goes past the hull, black, with the new stars in it.

MANU She did.

He stands there a while longer. He does not say anything else. Then he goes back to the sweep and holds the new heading, and some time after midnight a new swell comes under the canoe, small, from the north-east, bent around something, and he feels it, every time.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAWN, DAY 28

Tamatoa is in the bow with a shell. He cuts a notch in the rail beside him, the first.

Roa is under the deck lifting gourds. He sets them down in a row where everyone can count them, and there are six.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT

The small star turns off the port bow on the new heading.

Manu is at the sweep with Koa beside him, awake as always.

Manu looks at the boy for a while. Then he takes the boy's hand and lifts it and points it at the small star.

MANU Hold it there.

KOA Why?

MANU Just hold it.

The boy holds it. Manu lets go. The hand stays.

MANU Now look where your hand is against the hull. That corner on the port bow is where it lives. If it moves off that corner, we've turned.

KOA What if there's cloud?

MANU Then you find it by the ones around it, that one and that one. They turn round it, so if you can see any of them you can find the hole.

Koa looks. He has the face of a boy being given a job he did not ask for.

KOA Why are you telling me?

Manu does not answer at once.

MANU Because if I go over the side, it goes with me. Everything I know is in my head and nowhere else.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT — LATER

There are more of them now: Vaea, arms folded, a little apart, and Roa because she is there, and two of the younger warriors, and the old woman with the child.

Manu on his knees on the deck, drawing the ring of stones on the planks with a wet fingertip, and it dries as he draws it and he draws it again.

MANU That one rises here and sets there. Every one of them does, every night. You don't

need all of them. You need six, and these are the six.

He looks up at Vaea.

MANU You're not listening.

VAEA I don't need to. I'm not the one steering.

MANU You will be, one night. Come and sit down.

She unfolds her arms, and comes and kneels down, and puts her own finger on the plank.

In the bow, Tamatoa's eyes are open. They have been open the whole time. He looks at his own forearm, at nothing.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 29

Tamatoa cuts the second notch in the rail.

Roa counts the gourds, and there are five. A child is crying in the hull, thinly, and nobody going to it, because there is nothing to bring.

Akau unrolls his cloth on the deck: the bone combs, the mallet, the shell of black.

Nobody laughs this time.

AKAU If it's only in his head, it goes down with him.

He looks at Manu.

AKAU You wouldn't look at me on the beach.

MANU No.

AKAU Look now.

He turns his own forearm up. He dips the comb. He lays it against the inside of his own forearm, sets the mallet, and taps.

There is black under the skin, a point.

AKAU The hole in the sky.

He taps again, a thumb's width off.

AKAU The small one that turns round it.

He works. It hurts and he does not stop. The crew gather. When he has six points on his arm and the lines between them, he holds it up to Manu.

AKAU Is it right?

Manu takes the arm. Turns it to the light. Looks at it a long time.

MANU That one's high.

Akau taps it lower.

MANU Yes.

Akau looks round.

AKAU Who's next?

Koa is already holding out his arm.

TAMATOA (*from the bow*) No ink on the boy.

AKAU It's his arm.

Tamatoa stands and comes down the deck, which he has not done since the cords went over. The crew watch him come.

Koa does not take the arm back. He holds it out, at the level of Tamatoa's belt, and looks at the sea and not at the war chief, and waits.

Tamatoa looks at the arm, and at the boy, and at the crew, who are looking at him.

He goes back to the bow and sits down.

Akau taps.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — MONTAGE

Arms, one after another, in the sun. Akau taps in the rhythm of the paddling chant, and each of them sings it under their breath to bear it.

Koa's thin one, with the boy's jaw set; Vaea's, and she does not look at the needle once; Roa's; the two young warriors'; and the old woman's, who holds the child with one arm and gives Akau the other.

Hina holds out her arm. Akau hesitates: she is the Chief's daughter, and the ink on her is a matter for priests.

TAMATOA Not her.

She does not withdraw the arm. She does not look at Tamatoa. She looks at Akau until he taps.

Tihoti watches. He does not hold out an arm. But he does not stop it, either, and when Akau finishes each one he looks at the arm and nods, once, as if a name has been recorded.

By dusk of the second day the chart is on twelve forearms.

The sun goes down on a canoe full of people looking at the insides of their own arms.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DUSK

The light is going, and the new heading is held.

Something in the water ahead: a mat of weed, yellow-green, drifting. Roa reaches over and hauls up a fistful, and it is wet and alive, with small crabs in it.

He holds it up. Nobody says anything. Everyone looks at it.

Then, high, a black shape with a forked tail, hanging on the wind, going nowhere: a frigate bird.

Then, as the sun touches the water, two white birds come past the canoe, low, fast, close enough to hear the wings. They are terns, both going the same way, north-north-east, without a glance at the canoe, like people going home.

TIHOTI The god sent them.

MANU They're going to bed.

KOA It doesn't matter.

Manu looks at the boy. Tihoti looks at the boy. Neither of them argues.

Manu moves the sweep a hand's width toward the terns' line.

TAMATOA Two days.

He is standing in the bow, with the shell in his hand and the two notches beside him.

TAMATOA I gave you two days, and what we've got is birds.

MANU Birds that sleep on land.

TAMATOA Then show me the land.

Manu cannot, and nobody can. There is nothing on the horizon but the place the terns went.

Tamatoa looks at the crew. Every face is turned north-north-east. Not one is turned to him. He counts them, the way he counted baskets on the beach. Then he looks at their arms: twelve forearms, the same six points on each, the chart that does not need him or his brother.

A canoe that can steer itself cannot be turned by one man. He knows it as a fact. He sits down.

Before the light is gone he has Roa move the last five full gourds astern, into the small canoe on its tow-line.

TAMATOA (*loud enough for the deck*) It rides drier.

It does. Roa lashes them in. Vaea watches him do it, and looks at the tow-line, and at her husband's hands on the lashings, and says nothing.

Tamatoa looks at the sky behind them, to the south. It has gone a colour it should not be.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT

It comes out of the south with no warning but the colour.

It comes as a wall, black on black, the stars going out in a line from the horizon upward, faster than a man can point at them. The wind arrives before the rain and it arrives all at once.

The sail goes from full to something trying to leave. The boom swings. The canoe heels, the port hull lifting clear, and comes down with a crack that goes through everyone's teeth.

Then the rain comes, sideways.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

It is chaos, in the dark, in pieces.

Tihoti with the pahu between his knees, beating the stroke for the paddles that are still in, until a wave takes the drum out of his hands and over the side, and the beat stops.

Men on the boom, trying to get the sail down. It will not come. It tears instead, a sound like a scream, and half of it goes out over the water like a bird.

The mast cracks, low, at the step. It holds, and then it cracks again.

A pig, tied by the legs, sliding across the deck and over the side without a sound.

Gourds go over. Someone grabs for one and gets the lashing and nothing else. Others break where they are, against the crossbeam, the water in them running out across the deck into the water coming over it.

Koa with both arms around the trough of cuttings, flat on the deck, being washed along it and back.

Hina in the starboard hull, up to her waist, with the old woman and the two infants, holding one child above the water with both arms and nothing to hold on with. A dog swimming in the hull beside her with its head up and its eyes on her face.

Manu is at the sweep with the water coming over him in solid pieces, holding it. The heading

is gone; there is no heading; there is only keeping the bows to the sea.

A wave takes him off it. He is on the deck. The sweep is swinging free.

Vaea has it.

She has come from nowhere and she has the sweep in both hands and her feet braced against the crossbeam, and she is holding it. Not the way Manu holds it. The way a planter holds a digging stick when the ground fights back.

She looks up. Through the rain, for half a second, there is a gap in the cloud, and in it the small star and the hole it turns round.

She puts the bows where it told her.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — STERN — CONTINUOUS

The small canoe, the one-man hull they have towed since the reef, is lashed astern with the last full gourds in it.

Tamatoa is at the tow-line with a blade.

Roa is with him. Tamatoa is shouting into his ear over the wind, and Roa's face, lit by nothing, by the white of the water, is the face of a man being told something he does not want to have heard.

TAMATOA — south. We run with it, the two of us. The water's in it.

ROA Vaea.

TAMATOA There's no room.

Roa looks at the blade. He looks along the deck at the sweep, where his wife is, with her feet against the crossbeam and the whole sea trying to take it out of her hands.

He does not cut the line.

He does not say no. He does not do anything. He stands with his hand on the line and does not cut it, for one second, and two, and three.

Three is enough.

Manu hits Tamatoa from the side.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

It is not a warrior's fight. The deck is under a hand of water and tilting through forty degrees and there is nothing to stand on.

Manu has surprise and nothing else. Tamatoa has everything else.

Manu gets one arm around his brother's neck. Tamatoa breaks it with an elbow that puts Manu's head into the deck. Manu comes up. Tamatoa hits him in the face, once, and Manu goes back across the deck and into the lashings of the crossbeam and stays there.

Tamatoa stands over him. Rain on both of them. There is no anger in it.

TAMATOA You're a weight.

He turns back to the small canoe. Roa is still holding the line, and has still not cut it.

TAMATOA Roa.

Manu, on his back in the lashings, sees it.

Over Tamatoa's shoulder, coming out of the dark: the sea rising, not as a wave but as a slope, a black hill with white on it, and the hill is standing up, and the port hull is going to be under it.

MANU (*screaming*) HOLD ON —

Tamatoa does not turn. He has never once turned when Manu spoke.

MANU TAMATOA —

The hill arrives.

The port hull goes up like a thrown thing. The deck stands on its edge. Everything that is not lashed leaves. Manu is in the lashings and the lashings hold.

Tamatoa is not in anything.

He goes over the side backward, into the white, and the white closes over the place, and there is nothing there.

Astern, the tow-line goes bar-taut and parts like a struck string, and the small canoe, with the last full gourds in it, goes into the same white and does not come out.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

Manu is on the deck as it comes back down, with the water pouring off it.

He looks at the place where his brother went in, and there is nothing there but sea.

He looks at it for the length of a breath, and then another. Along the deck: Vaea on the sweep, Koa under the trough, Hina at the hatch with a child. None of them is looking at him.

Roa, at the line, is. He sees him look at the water. He sees him decide.

He goes over the side.

At the hatch of the starboard hull, Hina, with a child in her arms, sees him go. She does not scream. She cannot let go of the child. She watches the place where he went in, and the place stays empty.

EXT. UNDERWATER — CONTINUOUS

It is black, and the roar is gone. There is just the pressure and the cold and the pull of the water going everywhere at once.

There is nothing.

He turns in the black and there is no up. He has lost him. He has lost the hull. There is only the cold and the pull.

Then, below him, there is a shape, heavier than the water, going down.

He goes down after it. Reaches it. Gets a fist in the hair. Kicks, and does not know which way.

The pull tells him. He goes with it.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

They come up together in the trough between two hills. Tamatoa is not helping. He is a weight.

Manu gets an arm across his chest from behind and turns on his back and kicks for the hull.

It is the hold that took a screaming boy out of the surf at Nuku Hiva fifteen years ago.

The hull, and a hand, Roa's, and another, Vaea's, one hand, the other still on the sweep.

They haul. Tamatoa comes over the rail like something landed, and Manu comes after him.

Manu lies on the deck for the length of one wave.

The ones on deck saw it: Roa, Vaea, Koa flat under the trough, Hina at the hatch. Nobody says anything. Roa lets go of the tow-line, which he has been holding since the wind came, and it is not there to hold.

Then he gets up and takes the sweep out of Vaea's hands. She has not let go of it since he fell. She lets go now.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — LATER

The mast down, snapped at the step, lashed along the deck. A scrap of sail rigged on a paddle in the bow.

Manu at the sweep, not fighting the sea. Letting it come from behind. Running with it. The

bows lifting on each hill and sliding down the far side.

The rain eases, and then the wind, and then, low in the west, there is a strip of sky with stars in it.

INT. HULL — LATER THAT NIGHT

The starboard hull, half full of water. Tamatoa lying in it with his back against the planks. Something is wrong with his chest; he holds one arm across it and breathes in small pieces.

No one is with him.

Then Manu, coming down the ladder. His face is swollen on one side where the fist landed. He sits on the crossbeam above the water. He does not say anything.

They stay like that.

TAMATOA You want to know what's down there.

Manu does not answer.

TAMATOA Nothing.

He breathes. Something in his chest moves that should not.

TAMATOA No god, no road, nobody. It's black and it's cold and it goes down. That's all there is.

MANU You were under for —

TAMATOA Long enough to look.

Water slaps in the hull.

TAMATOA Forty men, and I've counted them: thirty-one on the ground and nine in the water. I told every one of them the same thing while I did it, that they were going down the road to the old ones, somewhere.

He looks at the black water round his legs.

TAMATOA There isn't any road. There's just that, and I put nine men in it and told them it was a road.

Manu says nothing. There is nothing to say to it.

TAMATOA You should have let go.

MANU You didn't.

Tamatoa looks at him.

He has no reply to that. He looks for one. His mouth moves. Nothing comes.

He turns his face to the planks, and he does not turn it back.

Manu stays on the crossbeam until his brother's breathing changes into sleep. Then he stays a while longer.

CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY 30

The sea is flat again, grey and slow. The storm is gone.

Te Ivi sits low. The mast lashed along the deck like a body. The scrap of sail on its paddle hangs. Nothing moves it.

The crew are on the deck and do not look like the same people. Two are missing. So is one of the infants.

The woman who turned her child's face to the sisters sits at the rail with her arms still in the shape they were in. Nobody sits near her. Nobody sits far.

Tihoti has the cord. He ties a knot, and then a second, and then a third.

Hina, at the stern, sings under her breath. Three names go into the chant. The third is an infant's, and it is very short, and it takes her a long time to sing.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

Roa going along the gourds. He does not shake them. He lifts each, and sets it down, and moves to the next, and the count is so short he does not need to say it.

Half the water went with the small canoe when the line parted. The rest is in whichever gourds did not break. Nobody has said Tamatoa's name in connection with the small canoe, and nobody will.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAY — LATER

There is nothing on any horizon.

The crew do not speak of dying. They speak of other things.

A YOUNG WARRIOR Fetu owes me a fishhook.

ANOTHER Fetu's dead.

THE FIRST He still owes me.

VAEA What did breadfruit taste like?

ROA You know what it tasted like.

VAEA Tell me anyway.

He tells her. It takes a while. Other people add things.

Koa is at the trough. The moss is nearly dry. He bends over it and lets a thread of spit run from his mouth onto the shoots, one after another, and does not seem to think it strange.

Tamatoa lies against the crossbeam. He cannot stand. Hina is beside him with a wet cloth, and she wets his lips with it, and does not look at Manu, who is at the sweep, and has not looked at her since the bow.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — NIGHT

The stars are out, all of them, the small one turning off the port bow, where Vaea put it.

Manu leaves the sweep. He goes to the bow and stands at the rail where Tihoti stands, and this time he does not look over his shoulder.

He speaks to the water, quietly, and it is not a prayer.

MANU Her name was Moeata.

The water goes past the hull.

MANU Her mother was Tepua. Her mother's mother was Hakaiki. She made nets. She lay in the hull and she could feel you through the wood, and she told me, and I didn't listen, and she's in you now.

He stops. His hands are on the rail.

MANU That's her name, Moeata, and I'm telling it to you.

He stands there. Then he goes back to the sweep.

Behind him, on his mat, Tihoti's eyes are open. They close.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — DAWN, DAY 32

The light coming up grey, then pink.

Koa at the bow, as always, first. Looking north, as always, hardest.

He goes still.

Then he does not shout. He turns and looks at Manu, and Manu sees the boy's face and comes forward, and looks.

To the north, low, there is a line of cloud along the horizon, and above the cloud, higher than cloud, there is something white.

It is not a cloud. Clouds move. This does not move. It sits above the cloud with the first light on it, and it is a shape, and the shape has a top.

MANU (*very quiet*) Don't wake them.

KOA Why?

MANU I want to be sure.

They watch it. The light strengthens. It does not move. It gets whiter.

MANU Wake them.

EXT. OPEN OCEAN — CONTINUOUS

The crew on their feet, in a line along the rail, looking at it. No one speaks. They do not know what it is. It is deep winter and none of them has ever seen snow, or heard of it, or has a word. The wind coming off the mountain is cold. None of them has ever been cold. Their skin does something none of them has seen it do.

A WOMAN What is it?

Nobody knows.

Hina comes forward through them. She looks at it for a long moment. Her mouth opens.

Then she sings.

HINA (*sung, full voice, the first time we have heard it*) ...and they came to the mountain whose hair is white...

The crew turn to her.

HINA (*sung*) ...and they came home, and sang it, and the ones who heard it are the ones we come from.

She stops. She is looking at the mountain. She is weeping. We have not seen that before.

Tihoti, beside her, says nothing. He takes the cord from his arm. He does not tie a knot. He holds it, and looks at the mountain, and puts the cord back.

Manu is not looking at the mountain. He is looking at Hina. Then he goes back to the sweep, because someone has to.

EXT. KA LAE — DAY

Land. It is not the mountain, which is far inland and lost in cloud now, but the mountain's

foot. A low point of black lava running out into the sea, ropy and glassy and sharp enough to open a foot, windswept, treeless, with a broken cinder cone standing above a small bay.

The current runs hard off the point. Te Ivi, under paddles, fights across it and into the bay, and the paddles hit sand.

The sand is green.

It glitters. Olivine, though no one aboard will ever know the word: green crystals ground out of the cone by the sea, a colour none of them knew sand could be.

And it is covered in birds.

There are plovers, hundreds of them, fat and sleek and wintering, the same birds. They are walking on the green sand exactly as they walked on the grey sand at Nuku Hiva the morning Te Ivi cleared the reef, taking no interest in anything.

The crew come over the side into the shallows and stand in the water and look at them.

The birds do not fly. They walk up to the crew the way they never did at home, where a plover was food, and one of them looks at Vaea's ankle and walks on.

EXT. KA LAE — FROM HIGH ABOVE — CONTINUOUS

From the height of a bird. The black point, the green bay, the canoe in the shallows, and twenty small figures standing in the water among a thousand smaller ones. And behind them, filling the frame, the land going up and up into cloud.

Manu comes down last. He wades ashore. He walks up the green sand among the birds, and they part round his feet and close behind him, and he sits down.

He sits in the sand with the birds around him.

He tries to say something. Nothing comes. He puts a hand flat on the sand, the way he put it flat on the rock on the ridge, and holds it there.

Koa comes and sits beside him with the trough in his arms, and does not say anything either.

EXT. KA LAE — CONTINUOUS

Tamatoa, over Roa's shoulder, half-carried, half-dragged up the beach. He can barely stand. He is holding his spear.

He gets to the top of the sand. He gets his feet under him. Roa lets go.

Tamatoa drives the spear into the green sand, and holds it, and stays standing.

TAMATOA (*hoarse*) I take this land in my name.

Nobody cheers.

They look at him. Then they look at the point: rock and wind, no trees, no water, no shade, and birds.

VAEA It's a rock.

She says it flat.

Tamatoa looks at the spear in the sand. He does not take it out. He does not have the strength to take it out. He lets go of it, and it stays, and Roa catches him.

EXT. KA LAE — NIGHT

There is a fire on the green sand, of driftwood, not much of it. The crew around it, the birds asleep beyond the light.

Nobody is celebrating. They have crossed the sea to a rock, with a mountain behind it that they cannot reach.

Koa, by the fire, with the trough. He is counting the cuttings. His lips move. He touches each one.

Manu watches him.

KOA Twelve.

MANU Out of how many?

KOA Twenty-four.

That is half. Manu nods. He does not say anything about arithmetic.

KOA Twelve is enough.

MANU Is it?

KOA It has to be.

EXT. THE COAST — DAY — DAYS LATER

This is one shot.

Te Ivi, under a jury mast, a paddle lashed upright with the scrap of sail on it, working up the coast in the lee of the island.

Behind her, going away, the black point, and on it, very small, a spear standing in green sand, claiming it.

Ahead the land rises, black rock, then green on the black, and then, as the coast turns,

cliffs, and off the cliffs, white threads: waterfalls, dozens, falling into the sea. And above the cliffs, forest, going up into the cloud.

And above the cloud, far inland, the white summit. And beyond it, a second one.

The canoe rounds the last headland, and the coast opens.

A valley opens, a gash in the cliffs a mile wide, walls green to the top, and out of the floor of it a river running clear across a beach of black sand into the sea.

Nobody says anything. There is nothing to say. Manu puts the sweep over, and the bows come round, and Te Ivi goes in.

EXT. WAIPI'O — BLACK SAND BEACH — DAY

The canoe is grounded and the crew are ashore, standing in the river mouth with the fresh water running over their feet, drinking from their hands.

Koa carries the trough up the beach as if it were an infant and sets it down beside the river.

EXT. WAIPI'O — THE RIVER — CONTINUOUS

The crew in the river to their knees. The water is cold, and it is coming down the valley in a quantity none of them has ever seen in one place, and it does not stop coming.

Vaea cups it and drinks and cups it and drinks and then just stands in it with her hands open under the surface, letting it go through her fingers, because there is more.

Something touches her ankle. She looks down. The river bed is moving. Fish, small, dark, in numbers, going upstream over the stones as if the stones were not there. Roa puts his hands in and lifts, and there are two in his hands, and he laughs. It is the first laugh since the rain, and it goes down the line of them the way the rain did.

EXT. WAIPI'O — THE VALLEY FLOOR — CONTINUOUS

Up from the beach there are tree-ferns, hāpu'u, with trunks, higher than a man, their new fronds curled like fists and covered in gold hair. And out of the ferns, unhurried, comes a bird.

It is the size of a goose and it cannot fly. It walks up to the young warrior, and looks at him, and he bends and picks it up, and it does not struggle. He holds it against his chest and looks at the others with his mouth open.

There are more of them. They come out of the ferns to see what the noise is.

EXT. WAIPI'O — THE FOREST EDGE — CONTINUOUS

Manu, alone, at the foot of a tree. Koa: grey bark, a trunk wider than his arms will reach,

leaves like curved blades.

He puts his hand on it. He looks up. It goes up past where the sacred canoe would end if it were stood on its stern, and keeps going. Back on Nuku Hiva there is not one tree left that would make a mast, and here there are hundreds, with more behind them.

EXT. WAIPI'O — TERRACE GROUND — CONTINUOUS

Vaea on her knees, away from the others, with her hands in the earth.

She brings up a fistful. It is black, and wet, and it holds together when she closes her hand and falls apart when she opens it. She smells it.

She does not say anything. She is a planter, and she is crying, and she goes on holding the earth.

Koa comes up the bank with the trough. He looks at her hands. He sets the trough down, and takes out the first cutting, and gives it to her.

EXT. WAIPI'O — BLACK SAND BEACH — DUSK

There is a fire, the first real one, with fish on the coals, more than they can eat, and one of the fat birds, and the fern-shoots Vaea found, roasted, and water going round in gourds that nobody is counting. The dogs get fish, whole ones.

They eat. For a long time nobody says anything, because they are eating.

Then, with the fire down to coals, somebody slaps a gourd. The pahu went over the side in the storm; a gourd is what there is. Another slaps a thigh. The women get up, three of them, garlands of fern, firelight on wet skin, the ink on their arms and bellies moving with them, and dance on the black sand in front of the coals, hands and hips, the dance for a good catch, and the men watch, and then the men are up too, stamping, the bark of the war chant coming out of them with fish in their mouths, and it is not short this time, because they have the breath.

Hina does not dance. She sits by Tamatoa with the cloth for his lips. Manu, across the fire, watches her not dance.

Beyond the light, in the ferns, the fat birds come out to see what the noise is.

Tamatoa on his feet, with Roa a step behind him, not touching him. He has watched all of it. He is looking up the valley.

It goes back and back. Terraces could go there, and houses there. The river runs the length of it and there is more flat ground in one valley than on the whole of Nuku Hiva.

He is doing arithmetic, counting the men he has, which is twelve, and counting the ground.

A place this big does not need to be held by force. It needs to be built.

He looks down at the whale-bone club in his hand. He has carried it across two thousand four hundred miles of sea.

He walks down the beach. It hurts him to walk. He gets to where Manu is standing at the water's edge, and he stops, and he bends, which hurts him more, and lays the club in the black sand at his brother's feet.

He straightens.

Manu looks at the club. He does not pick it up.

He steps forward and puts his forehead against his brother's, and his nose against his brother's nose, and holds it there, the breath between them, as equals.

Tamatoa's hand comes up and takes the back of Manu's neck, the way it took Hina's on the beach at Nuku Hiva.

They stand like that.

The club stays in the sand. The river runs past it. Nobody picks it up, that day or any other.

FADE OUT.

EXT. WAIPI'O — THE TERRACES — DAY (WINTER)

It is raining, a cold rain, the first any of them has stood in.

Terraces going in, a dozen people up to their shins in black mud, and the mud does not do what Nuku Hiva mud did. Vaea is showing them with her hands. She has stopped explaining. She just does it, and they watch, and then they do it.

Tamatoa, with a digging stick, in the mud with the others. He is bad at it. He digs the way he fights, all at once, and the bank collapses. Vaea looks at him. He looks at the bank. He starts again, slower.

Koa on the highest terrace, alone, setting the first corm in with both hands round it, and packing the mud, and sitting back on his heels and looking at it for a long time as if it might move.

EXT. WAIPI'O — THE HEIAU SITE — NIGHT (WINTER)

A shelf of the valley wall. Stones, dragged up in the day, lying where they were dropped.

A half-coconut cup on a stone between them, and in it a finger's depth of kava, the first

from the root that crossed. Tihoti drinks, and holds out the cup, and Manu, who has never in his life been handed it, looks at it, and drinks, and makes the face everyone makes.

Then Manu with a cord stretched between two stakes. Tihoti holding the other end. Above them, the small star turning round its hole.

MANU Move your end toward me.

Tihoti moves it.

MANU There.

He sights along the cord at the hole in the sky. Tihoti sights along it too. The cord points at nothing.

TIHOTI You are laying a house of the gods to a hole.

MANU Yes.

TIHOTI A thing with no mother.

MANU Everything turns round it, every star you've got a mother for. Whatever it is, they all go round it.

Tihoti looks at the hole for a long time.

TIHOTI She lay in the hull and did not move, when everyone else on the canoe did.

Manu says nothing.

TIHOTI If it has to have a name, sing it as the one who did not move. I know her mother; I sang her.

He drives his stake in. The cord holds.

EXT. WAIPÍ'O — THE HEIAU SITE — DAY (WINTER)

A body on a mat. One of the two younger warriors. He does not look sick. He looks like a man who stopped.

Tihoti sings him under, into the black earth this time instead of the water, and ties a knot, the sixth. The cord is getting long.

Behind him, the heiau is one course high. Beyond that, the terraces are green.

INT. HOUSE — WAIPÍ'O — NIGHT (WINTER)

Akau has Tamatoa's arm across his knees, and the needle, and the mallet.

Tamatoa does not look at it. He looks at the fire. He has not asked for this, and he has not

refused it, and he has not spoken since Akau sat down.

AKAU The hole.

He taps.

AKAU The small one that turns.

He taps.

After a while, without turning his head:

TAMATOA How many arms is it on?

AKAU Thirteen. Yours is fourteen.

TAMATOA And if I'd cut the line.

AKAU Then not yours.

He taps. Tamatoa watches the fire, and the star points go in.

EXT. WAIPI'O VALLEY — DAWN, SPRING

Months have passed.

The valley floor from above. Terraces, new, stepping down to the river, and the water in them is green with the first taro. Along the river, a row of small trees, thigh-high, broad-leaved: the breadfruit, out of Koa's trough.

Houses on stone platforms, the stone black. In front of one, a woman with a stone pounder and a board, pounding taro, the first pounding this valley has heard. From another, the beaters going on a log: bark cloth. The rhythm has no gap in it.

And above them, on a shelf of the valley wall, a rectangle of fitted stone, unfinished, one corner still open: a heiau, its long side laid to the point in the northern sky where nothing is. From its post hangs a cord with eleven knots in it, four from the sea and seven from the first winter, which was the hungrier.

The sound of wings, thousands of them.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE WAIPI'O — CONTINUOUS

The plovers are leaving. The whole valley floor lifts at once, and turns, and goes north over the cliffs and out over the sea, thinner than they came, going somewhere.

Manu on the ridge, watching them go. He has climbed up here to see it. He is alone.

He watches until they are a line, and then a mark on the sky, and then nothing.

He turns to go down. He stops.

EXT. RIDGE — CONTINUOUS

At his feet, half under grass, on a shelf of flat rock: pebbles.

They are in a ring, thirty-odd of them, two arm-spans across. The grass has grown through it and some of the stones have gone under, but the shape is there, and the shape is exact.

Manu stands very still.

He crouches. He puts a hand flat on the rock beside the ring. He does not touch the stones.

He looks at where they point.

They point south. Not north, and not the angle from the beach, but south, along the line the canoe came, toward the reef and the ash and the marae. They point home.

EXT. STREAM BED — CONTINUOUS

Below the shelf, the ridge falls away into a gully choked with vines. He goes down into it, fast, tearing, not caring.

At the bottom, in the wet, under a mat of green: a shape.

It is a hull, small, one man's, the wood black and soft and going back into the ground. He pulls the vines off it with his hands.

It has been worked on. The stem has been cut back and a new one shaped and never fitted; it lies beside the hull, rotted to the same black. Fresh lashing-holes have been bored along the gunwale, and none of them lashed. A mast-step has been half cut. The stream runs under it, because he dragged it here to launch it.

He was going back.

At the bow, where the lashings held the stem, a knot. Most of the lashings have rotted. This one is still there, dark, tight, and it is a knot with a turn in it that no one ties. No one but one man, and the man's son, who does not know he does it. His mother tied his stones with it on the last night.

He puts his fingers on it. He does not pull it.

Wrapped in the bow, under the thwart, something else: a knotted cord. He lifts it out and it comes apart in his hands, soft as bread, and the knots go to nothing between his fingers.

He looks for the rest, and there is no rest, no bones, no mat, no fire-pit, nothing but a small canoe in a stream bed and a ring of stones on the ridge above it. The stream has had fifteen years to take whatever else was here.

EXT. STREAM BED — LATER

He sits in the hull. He has been sitting in it a long time. The light has gone across the gully and is climbing the far wall.

His father made it here, and laid his stones on the ridge, and pointed them north, and went down into this gully, and died in it, alone, with no one to tell.

He puts a hand on the unfitted stem where it lies in the mud beside the hull. He looks at the bored holes, one after another, along the gunwale, the way he counted knots.

MANU You were going back.

That is all he says.

TEIKI (V.O.) When I come back, they'll have to.

The voice from the beach. The boy's hand pointing north.

Manu looks up, through the gap in the vines, at the sky, where the last of the plovers have gone.

He sits in his father's canoe until it is dark.

INT. HOUSE — WAIPI'O — NIGHT (AUTUMN)

A child cries, new and thin and furious.

Hina on the mat, spent, the women around her. The child on her chest.

Tamatoa in the doorway, and he does not come in until she looks at him. Then he comes in, and the women give him room, and he takes the child.

He holds it badly. He looks at it.

Then he looks past the women, to the door, where Manu is standing, and he holds the child out.

Manu comes in and takes it. He holds it worse.

The two of them stand over the mat with the child between them, and Hina watches them from the mat with her eyes half shut, and does not say anything.

INT. HOUSE — LATER THAT NIGHT

The women have gone. The child asleep against her. Tamatoa alone, sitting by the fire.

Hina is watching him.

HINA She isn't yours.

He does not move.

HINA I went to your house the night of the council. I'd counted; it was three weeks from the waterfall. I went so that she'd have a name that could keep her alive on the canoe. And on the canoe I said she was yours so that he'd keep his.

The fire burns between them.

HINA Every word I said to you was true. Seven mornings, and one night in your house. It was the sum that was the lie. Her line goes in the chant tonight. I won't sing it wrong.

She waits. She has said the most dangerous thing she will ever say, to the most dangerous man she knows, in a house with no one else in it.

Tamatoa is silent a long time.

He looks at the child.

TAMATOA On the sand at Nuku Hiva I held a boy who wasn't mine either.

Hina does not breathe.

TAMATOA I held him till the sail was gone. He bit me.

He looks at his own forearm. A small old scar there. Under it, the star points.

Then he looks at her.

TAMATOA Do you still want to go home?

HINA I'm not going home. I'm going to get them. The line goes where the food is, and the food is here.

EXT. BLACK SAND BEACH — DAWN, DAYS LATER

Te Ivi in the shallows, re-lashed and low with cargo. The new mast is koa, taller than the one the storm took, cut from a tree that could not have grown on Nuku Hiva, and the new sail is pandanus from the valley floor, wider than the old one. She is a better canoe than the one that came.

Seven are going and six are staying, and the child.

Tamatoa is at the sweep. He has the star points on both forearms now, fresh, the skin still angry round them. Akau did them over three nights.

Roa boards. Vaea does not come down to the beach. She is on the terrace above the river with her hands in the earth, and she does not look up until the sail is small, and then she does. Roa's eyes go to the terrace, once.

Tihoti at the water's edge, the cord in his hand. He does not board yet.

He walks up the beach to Manu, and stops, and lifts the cord, the eleven knots, and puts it over Manu's head, and lets it fall against his chest.

TIHOTI The stones on the hill are yours to keep until a priest comes.

MANU I'm not a priest.

TIHOTI No, you're not. Keep them anyway.

He puts a hand on the cord where it lies on Manu's chest.

TIHOTI At the bow, the night before the mountain, you said her name, and her mother's, and her mother's mother's. Nobody taught you that, and it was right.

He takes his hand away, and goes down the beach, and wades out, and is helped aboard, and keeps his face to the sea, because he has already sung this beach into the chant and does not need to see it again.

EXT. BLACK SAND BEACH — CONTINUOUS

Hina, at the top of the beach, with the child.

She has not explained. He has not asked. A chant no one hears is a dead person's chant, and the marae is at Nuku Hiva.

He walks up to her. He holds out his arms. She gives him the child.

He carries the child down the beach himself, into the shallows, to the hull. Roa reaches down, and he lifts the child up, and Roa takes her, and that is the last time he holds her.

Hina wades past him. She does not stop. She climbs aboard. She sits in the stern, where she has always sat, and she is already singing under her breath.

Tamatoa, at the sweep, looks at his brother in the water.

TAMATOA When I come back, they'll —

He stops. It is his father's sentence, the one from the beach, and he has heard himself start it.

TAMATOA I'll come back.

The paddles go in.

EXT. BLACK SAND BEACH — CONTINUOUS

Manu stands in the shallows to his knees. The canoe clears the river mouth. The sail goes up, and fills.

He watches it. It gets smaller. It becomes a shape, and a fleck, and then the light changes on the sea and it is not there.

He is still standing in the water. He has not moved.

Koa comes down the beach and stands beside him. Says nothing. After a while Manu turns and they walk up the black sand together, and the boy's shoulders are nearly at the man's now.

EXT. NUKU HIVA — THE REEF — DAY (WINTER)

The water is grey and so is the light. The beach runs the length of the frame, with the black hill above it, and the ash still falling, thinner now, because there is less left to burn.

On the water outside the reef, a sail.

The first person to see it is a child, and the child does not shout, because the child does not know what it is.

EXT. NUKU HIVA — BEACH — CONTINUOUS

They come down to the sand running, all of them. Nobody cheers. They stand at the water's edge and look at the canoe coming through the gap in the reef, and it is Te Ivi.

Kiato is at the front, older by more than a year and a half. He has walked down to this beach every morning since the sail went.

The hulls ground. Tamatoa comes over the side first, into the shallows, the star points black on both arms, and stands there in the water and does not come up the sand. Roa is behind him, and Tihoti, with the cord.

Then Hina, with a child on her hip.

She wades ashore, and walks up the sand to her father, and puts her forehead against his and her nose against his and holds it there with the child between them. He does not speak. When she lets go, she goes on up the path to the marae, and the crowd parts, and they follow her because they do not know what else to do.

At the back of the crowd, Manu's mother has stopped where she is. She has looked at every face that came over the side, and his was not among them.

EXT. COUNCIL MARAE — CONTINUOUS

The fitted stones and the last trees, in daylight this time.

Hina stands where she stood the night of the council, at the head, in her father's place, and he does not take it from her. She gives the child to Tihoti.

The sun is on her, and there is salt in her hair, and the blue line across each collarbone. The crowd is looking at her and not at the child.

She sings.

It is the chant of the crossing, from the tree Te Ivi was cut from: the reef, and the gap, and the birds on the sand; the first night with no island in the way; the three sisters going under, and the hair on the water; the hole in the sky; the rain that came from the south-west, and the woman who said it would, and lay in the hull, and did not move; the cords going into the sea; a wave, and three names; a white mountain, and a rock, and a valley with a river running out of it.

And in the place where the hollow is, she sings Moeata's name, and after it, Manu's.

At the back of the crowd his mother hears it, and sits down on the ground.

The elder who said *the navigator's other son* is at the edge of the marae. We stay on his face while the name is sung.

Kiato has sat down on the stones.

When she finishes she does not say anything. She holds out her arm, and Akau's star points are on it, and Tihoti holds out his, and Roa his, and Tamatoa, last, both of his.

The elder looks at the arms. Then he looks at the sea.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE WAIPĪ'O — DAWN, AUTUMN

A year has passed.

Manu on the ridge, beside his father's ring of stones. He has cleared the grass from it. He has not moved a single stone.

Koa is beside him, taller. The star points on his arm have gone from black to blue.

Below them the valley is green to the cliffs, with smoke from a dozen houses, and the heiau is finished, its corner closed.

The fat birds that walked out of the ferns that first day are harder to find now. Koa goes a long way up the valley for them.

And the sky filling up.

Wings, thousands of them: from the north, low over the sea, thin and exhausted, the plovers are coming home.

They pour over the cliffs and down into the valley and settle on the terraces and the black sand, everywhere, a whole sky's worth, going nowhere.

TEIKI (V.O.) *(the beach, fifteen years ago)* So they go somewhere.

Manu watches them land.

He does not point. His hands are at his sides.

Then, under the sound of the wings, there is another sound.

It comes from the water, from a canoe not yet in sight round the headland, close enough now to carry up the valley on the wind off the sea.

It is a voice, singing, and it is hers.

It is a genealogy, going back and back, and in it are names that are not in any chant that was ever sung on Nuku Hiva: the three sisters going under; the hole in the sky; a net-maker who lay in the hull; three who went over in a storm; a spear in green sand; a valley with a river.

Moeata's name is sung in the place where the hollow is.

Manu turns south.

Beyond the river mouth, on the sea, there are sails, and there is more than one.

FADE OUT.

TEXT CARD:

Around the year 1100, a canoe left the Marquesas Islands, in what is now French Polynesia, and sailed 2,400 miles north across open ocean to Hawai'i. That is the distance from New York to Los Angeles.

They had no charts, no instruments, and no metal. They steered by the stars, the swells, and the birds.

No one had ever lived there.

TEXT CARD:

The Marquesans became the first Hawaiians. Their descendants lived on the islands alone for more than six hundred years, until Captain James Cook arrived in 1778.

TEXT CARD:

Hawai'i became the fiftieth state of the United States on August 21, 1959.

END.